

Delhi plans new PG safety policy after Satya Niketan collapse

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi Government's plan to bring in a new safety policy for paying-guest accommodation may have been prompted by the Satya Niketan building collapse, but attempts to regulate PGs in the city go back more than three decades.

Chief Minister Rekha Gupta on Monday said the Delhi government, in coordination with the MCD, was working towards introducing a policy under which every building used for public activities, whether a PG, nursing home, school or any other institution, would be required to undergo periodic structural audits and obtain building safety certification. No building would be allowed to conduct public activities

without ensuring its safety.

Delhi Home Minister Ashish Sood said the Government will consider additional relaxation in Floor Area Ratio (FAR) and redevelopment of existing hostels to address the shortage of residential facilities for students. "There is a gap in residential facilities for the large number of students studying in various colleges in Delhi, including Delhi University colleges and universities run by the Delhi Government," Sood said. "Existing hostels can also be redeveloped by allowing enhanced FAR under the new provisions," he said.

Sood also said the Government discussed the regulation of Paying Guest (PG) accommodations and coaching institutes. He said a committee report was being prepared based on the recommendations of the Justice

Gupta Committee, and the regulation of PG accommodations was among the issues discussed at the meeting.

But records show that attempts to regulate paying-guest accommodation in Delhi go back to at least 1993, followed over the years by fresh schemes, surveys, committees and proposals for registration and licensing. A 2006 Delhi High Court judgment records that a "Paying Guest Residential Accommodation" scheme framed by the Centre was already in operation in the capital in 1993. "With a view to provide affordable and hygienic accommodation to foreign and domestic tourists, the central government formulated a scheme as per which residential buildings could be used for providing boarding and lodging to



tourists," the court said.

"It was a term of the scheme that the person availing benefit of the scheme should have his/her residence in the building. The scheme was called 'Paying Guest Residential Accommodation'," it added. The judgment referred to a South Extension Part-I Proper-

ty that was given permission in December 1993 to keep paying guests under the scheme.

The responsibility for regulating the scheme was subsequently transferred to the Delhi Government, which — then led by the Congress's Sheila Dikshit — approved its own Paying Guest

Residential Accommodation Scheme in 2000.

Under the scheme, house owners could register with the Delhi Tourism to keep paying guests. No more than half the bedrooms could be used for the purpose, with an upper limit of four rooms or eight beds. The scheme, however, was designed largely to provide tourists with affordable accommodation in homes where the owners themselves lived. It did not address the kind of large commercial PGs that later mushroomed around Delhi's universities, coaching hubs and employment centres.

And as the nature and scale of the PG business changed, regulation struggled to keep pace. Nearly two decades later, a Delhi Assembly committee examining problems faced by students around

the Delhi University (DU) was still asking basic questions about which rules applied to PGs and who was responsible for enforcing those.

At a meeting in August 2019, the Assembly's Committee on Petitions asked authorities to prepare a list of PGs and other establishments operating around the DU. More significantly, it sought a document spelling out the rules governing them and identifying "problems/grey areas in terms of regulation" relating to fire safety, building norms and health licences.

Officials were given 15 days to provide the information.

"However, no such documentation was received till date," the committee subsequently recorded in its report.

The exercise was followed by more attempts at surveys

and regulation. In 2021, the erstwhile North Delhi Municipal Corporation proposed surveying PGs, particularly around the DU's North Campus, and registering establishments being run as commercial businesses.

In 2022, following meetings involving the city government's home department, the Delhi Police and civic agencies, authorities proposed bringing around 700 private hostels and PGs used by college students under a Delhi Police licensing regime.

Officials acknowledged then that there was no statutory body specifically regulating such establishments. The proposed rules were to cover occupancy, kitchens, elevators, fire clearances and other facilities. Yet, a year later, the regulatory gaps were evident again.

LG orders inspection drives at PG accommodations

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Lieutenant Governor Taranjit Singh Sandhu on Monday directed authorities to carry out inspection drives in paying guest (PG) accommodation hubs, especially in houses that have prima facie violated height and floor restrictions.

Sandhu also directed the chief secretary to ensure that structural audits of all buildings in PG hubs are carried out within a week, according to a statement issued by the Lok Niwas on Monday.

In the wake of a building collapse in the Satya Niketan area, LG Sandhu along with Chief Minister Rekha Gupta held a high-level review



Delhi LG Taranjit Singh Sandhu, Delhi CM Rekha Gupta and others during a meeting on building safety, student accommodation and PG regulations across Delhi

meeting with top Government and Municipal Corporation of Delhi (MCD) officials.

"Committees of DM, DCP and DC (MCD) will proactively reach out to students living in PG accommodations and listen to their problems and

grievances; comprehensive database of students to be compiled," the Lok Niwas said.

"Creating panic by mindless sealing drives will only lead to students becoming homeless," the LG said, adding that "inspection drives should be

conducted in premises housing students as PGs and had prima facie violated height and floor restrictions".

The LG also directed that the DDMA control room with contact numbers must be made operational immediately if any disaster occurs. It should monitor the rescue operation, health-related treatment support in hospitals, authentic media release and coordination with relatives of the victims.

Minister of Urban Development Ashish Sood will head a committee to review institutional PG guidelines and explore alternative student accommodation through universities. "Directed the urban development minister to lead a com-

mittee with senior officials concerned to review institutional PG guidelines, explore alternative student accommodation through universities, MCD and DDA," the LG said in a post on X.

The LG further directed officials to assess the feasibility of using unutilised Delhi Development Authority (DDA) housing stock for student accommodation.

During the meeting, Sandhu also emphasised strict enforcement against unsafe buildings, clear institutional accountability and an emergency mechanism under the Delhi Disaster Management Authority (DDMA) for swift grievance redressal and crisis coordination.

DU VC asks colleges to review student housing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi University Vice-Chancellor Yogesh Singh on Monday asked college principals to review residential facilities for students and expedite ongoing hostel projects following the collapse of a multi-storey PG accommodation near South Campus that claimed the lives of seven students.

Singh convened a meeting of college principals to discuss the incident and observed a two-minute silence in memory of the deceased.

The VC said the loss of students' lives was a "massive blow" to the university and assured the affected families that the university stood ready to provide all possible



DU Vice-Chancellor Yogesh Singh

assistance. He urged principals to explore the feasibility of constructing new hostels, assess available space and Government schemes and prepare plans wherever possible.

"Prof Yogesh Singh stated that the aim should be to provide residential facilities

to the maximum number of students," the university said in a statement.

The meeting came as student organisations intensified protests demanding accountability over the collapse and the safety of students living in private accommodations.

Meanwhile, Atma Ram Sanatan Dharma College principal Gyantosh Kumar Jha said that the college had received information about two students who were staying at the collapsed PG building, one of whom, identified as Arpit Jha, a second-year B Com student from Ganganagar in Rajasthan, had died. The other student was injured and undergoing treatment at the AIIMS Trauma Centre, he said.

**Baba Farid University of Health Sciences**
Sadiq Road, Faridkot-151203
Ph: 01639-256232, 256236

ADMISSION TO BMLS COURSE THROUGH LATERAL ENTRY - SESSION 2026
1st Physical Walk-in Counselling on 10-09-2026
Candidates desirous of seeking admission to the BMLS Course through Lateral Entry are informed to appear personally for counselling on **10.09.2026 at 10:00 AM**. The admission application fee and prescribed tuition fee shall be collected on the spot.
Eligibility: DMLT with minimum 50% marks for admission to 2nd Year (3rd Semester).
Venue: Committee Room, BFUHS, Faridkot.
Candidates must attend in person with original documents for verification. Candidates allotted seats will have to deposit the prescribed fee on the spot.
Note: Candidates are advised to regularly visit the University website **www.bfuhhs.ac.in** for the details of the 1st Physical Walk-in Counselling, Prospectus and other admission-related updates.

REGISTRAR
3108/12/2026-27/14874 Dated CHD :- 07/09/2026

PUBLIC NOTICE
This is to notify that Applied Promotions and Publicity Private Limited, the owner of Flat No.C 1402, 13th Floor, Tower C,Godrej Summit, Sector 104, Dwarka Expressway, Gurugram, Haryana -122006 , has lost/misplaced their Property Folder containing all original title/property documents pertaining to the said flat including Apartment Buyer's Agreement, Flat Allotment Letter and all Payment Receipts. Any such original documents found or produced hereafter shall be treated as cancelled, null and void, and shall not confer any right, title, interest or claim whatsoever in respect of the said property.
Applied Promotions and Publicity Private Limited
Date: 08/09/2026
Place: New Delhi

PUBLIC NOTICE
Notice is hereby given to the General Public on behalf of our client i.e. ICICI Bank Ltd. that Mr.Balvinder Singh, Mr. Maninder Singh are owners of Plot No.12, admeasuring 420 sq. mtrs., in Block-B, situated at Sushant Lok, Phase-I, Gurugram, Haryana. vide sale deed dated 06.01.2020, registration No. 16091, executed by Mr. Deepak Mittal through SPA Mr. Ajay Kapur after demise of late Mrs. Renu Mittal, whereas will dated 08.06.2018 is not probated, & SMC of late Renu Mittal is not available, All Persons are hereby informed that above owners want to sale the said property to someone or its/their nominee who is taking a loan facility from our client for purchase the said property. If anybody including other surviving members of Renu Mittal having any objection/s upon the ownership of above owners its sale/mortgage, & any other kind of objection/litigation, Charge etc., kindly inform the undersigned in writing on the below mentioned address within 10 days of the present.
Kumar & Associates (Advocates & Consultants)
200, 1Ind Flr. 23, Shivaji Marg, Mori Nagar, N.Delhi-15
Legal@himalayilaw.com Ph: 011-41115527-28

PUBLIC NOTICE
FORM INC-26
Pursuant to Rule 30 of the Companies (Incorporation) Rules, 2014
BEFORE THE REGIONAL DIRECTOR NORTHERN REGION DIRECTORATE I, DELHI
In the matter of Companies Act, 2013, Section 13(4)
And
In the matter of
STRINGEE INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED
(CIN: U72900DL2022FTCA07129)
Having registered office at: 73, Front Basement, National Park, Lajpat Nagar-IV, New Delhi-110024
.....PETITIONER
Notice is hereby given that the Company proposes to make application under section 13 of the Companies Act, 2013 before the Hon'ble Regional Director, Northern Region Directorate I Bench at Delhi seeking confirmation of alteration of the clause II of the Memorandum of Association of the Company in terms of Special Resolution passed at its Extra-Ordinary General Meeting held on **20th August, 2026** to enable the Petitioner Company to change its Registered Office from the 'State of Delhi' to the 'State of Maharashtra'. Any person whose interest is likely to be affected by the proposed change of registered office of the Company may deliver either on MAC21 portal (www.mca.gov.in) by filing investor complaint form or cause to be delivered or sent by registered post of his/her objection supported by an affidavit stating the nature of his/her interest and grounds of opposition to the Regional Director, Northern Region Directorate I, at B-2 Wing, 2nd floor, Pt. Deendayal Anthyodaya Bhawan, 2nd floor, CGO Complex, New Delhi - 110003, within fourteen days from the date of publication of this notice with a copy to the Petitioner Company at its registered office.
For STRINGEE INDIA PRIVATE LIMITED
KARAN GILATI (Director)
DIN: 10291584
Date: 07.09.2026
Place: Mumbai

**NATIONAL FERTILIZERS LIMITED**
(A Government of India Undertaking)
Corporate Office: A-11, Sector-24, Noida-201301
NFL Phone No.: 0120-2412294, Ext.: 1102 & 1108 Mb.: 995876808/9417456844

Tender for Photographers/Videographers
NFL invites tenders from Noida / Delhi based experienced photographers having desired facilities for Photography / Videography jobs. In case photographer's studio is in Delhi, it must not be beyond 20 kms from our Corporate Office. Tender documents can be obtained from the office of the undersigned on any working day or can be downloaded from our website: www.nationalfertilizers.com under open category. The last date for submission of tenders in our office is 30.09.2026 till 3 PM. Any corrigendum(s) to this tender shall be published only on our above website.
Manager (CC)

The Management Committee of Vikas Cooperative Group Housing Society
West Enclave Pitampura, New Delhi-110034
is going to forward the name of
1. Mr Ashish Kumar - Membership No. 60
To registrar cooperative Societies for the allotment of MIG Flats in the above society. If anybody has any objection he/she can raise and sustain by writing to Hon'y. president of the society within 7 days from the date of publishing of this notice.
Regards Honorary President

PUBLIC NOTICE
I/W/Me, ROSHAN LAL JAIN S/o Late Ram Dev Jain and USHA JAIN W/o Roshan Lal Jain, R/o 292, Anandpuri, Kanpur, (U.P.) 208023 Present address : Flat No.-806, Amrapali Royal, Urvashi-2, Vaibhav Khand, Indrapuram, Ghaziabad (U.P.) 201014 debar/evict my elder son YOGESH JAIN from all our moveable/immovable properties in all manners due to their disobedience, misconduct and misbehavior, we will not be responsible for their any acts whatsoever in future.

THE HINDUSTAN TIMES LIMITED
CIN: U74899DL1927PLC000155
Registered Office: Hindustan Times House, 18-20, Kasturba Gandhi Marg, New Delhi 110 001
Tel.: 011 - 66561306
NOTICE
Notice is hereby given that 97th Annual General Meeting of the Company will be held on Wednesday, 30th September, 2026 at 10:00 A.M. at 'The Hains' Hotel, 15 Barakhamba Road, New Delhi-110001. Pursuant to Section 91 of the Companies Act, 2013, the Register of Members and Share transfer Books of the Company shall remain closed from Saturday the 19th September, 2026 to Tuesday, the 29th September 2026 both days inclusive for ascertaining the entitlement of the dividend to be declared in the Annual General Meeting.
Sd/-
Virendra Kumar Charoria
(Director & Company Secretary)
DIN: 00046895
Date: 07th September, 2026

AVIENCE BIOMEDICALS LIMITED
(Formerly known as Avience Biomedicals Private Limited)
Registered office: C-11, C-Block, Community Centre, Janakpuri, West Delhi, Delhi-110058, India
CIN: L74999DL2019PLC359158 | Website: www.avienbio.com
Ph. No. 011-46074944, 18001204636 | Email id: info@avienbio.com

07th ANNUAL GENERAL MEETING AND REMOTE E-VOTING

- This is to inform that 07th Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the Members of **Avience Biomedicals Limited** (the Company) will be convened on **Wednesday, September 30, 2026** at 11.30 A.M. through Video Conferencing (VC)/Other Audio Visual Means (OAVM) facility to be provided by the Central Depository Services Securities Limited (CDSL) in compliance with applicable provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 (the Act) and Rules framed thereunder.
 - In compliance with the provisions of General Circular No. 03/2025 dated 22.09.2025 and all other circulars issued by the Ministry of Corporate Affairs, Government of India (MCA) in this regard, (collectively referred to as 'MCA Circulars') read with applicable SEBI Circulars in this regard and in compliance with Section 101 and Section 108 of the Companies Act, 2013, read with Rule 18 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, and Regulation 36 of SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015, the Notice of the AGM along with the Annual Report for the Financial Year 2025-26 will be sent via electronic mode to those Members whose email addresses are registered with the Company / Depository Participants ("DPs").
 - To ensure receipt of the AGM Notice, Annual Report and user credentials for remote e-voting, Members who have not yet registered or updated their email addresses are requested to do so by following the procedure outlined below:
 - For Electronic Form (Demat Account Holders):** Members holding shares in electronic form are requested to contact and register/update their email addresses, mobile numbers, and bank account mandates directly with their respective Depository Participants (DPs) through whom they maintain their demat accounts. The Company or its RTA cannot act on direct requests for electronic shares.
 - For Physical Form (Paper Certificate Holders):** Members holding shares in physical form who have not registered/updated their email addresses are requested to submit a scan of a signed request letter specifying their Name, Folio Number, Mobile Number and Email Address, along with a self-attested copy of their PAN Card and Form ISR-1, to the Company's Registrar and Share Transfer Agent (RTA), Skyline Financial Services Private Limited at info@skylinerta.com.
 - Manner of Remote E-voting:** The Company is providing the facility of remote e-voting to all its Members to cast their votes electronically on all resolutions set forth in the AGM Notice. The detailed instructions and login process for e-voting will be provided inside the AGM Notice sent to your registered email IDs.
 - The Notice of AGM and Annual Report will also be available on the website of the Company www.avienbio.com, websites of the Stock Exchange i.e. National Stock Exchange of India Limited at www.nseindia.com and on the website of CDSL i.e. www.evotingindia.com.
- By Order of the Board Of Directors**
FOR AVIENCE BIOMEDICALS LIMITED
Sd/-
DHARAM DEO CHOUDHARY
Managing Director
DIN- 02804625
Address: Flat No 48, Suryodaya Apartment, Pocket 8, Sec-12, Dwarka, Dist: South West Delhi, Delhi – 110078
Place: New Delhi
Date: September 08, 2026

MY MONEY SECURITIES LIMITED
CIN : L67120DL1992PLC047890
Regd.Office : 10-A, UNDER HILLANE, CIVIL LINES, DELHI-110054
Contact No. : 011-47087455, 011-47087300, E-mail id : mymoneysecurities@outlook.com,
Information regarding 35thAnnual General Meeting of My Money Securities Limited
Notice is hereby given that the 35th Annual General Meeting (AGM) of the company will be held through Video Conferencing ("VC") / Other Audio Visual Means ("OAVM") on Sunday, 27th September, 2026 at 12:00 Noon (IST) to transact the business set out in the Notice convening the said AGM.
The 35th AGM will be held in compliance with the MCA General Circular No. 14/2020 dated 08 April 2020, Circular No. 17/2020 dated 13 April 2020, Circular No. 20/2020 dated 05 May 2020, Circular No. 02/2021 dated 13 January 2021, Circular No. 19/2021 dated 08 December 2021, Circular No. 21/2021 dated 14 December 2021, Circular No. 22/2022 dated 05 May 2022, Circular No. 10/2022 dated 28 December 2022, Circular No. 09/2023 dated 25 September 2023, Circular No. 09/2024 dated 19 September 2024 and Circular No. 03/2025 dated 22 September 2025 (issued in continuation of the foregoing, permitting AGMs/EGMs through VCOAVM/IF further orders), relevant provisions of the Companies Act, 2013 and the rules made thereunder and SEBI Circulars dated May 12, 2020, January 15, 2021, 13 May 2022, 5 January 2023, 7 October 2023 and 3 October 2024 read alongwith the applicable provisions of the SEBI (Listing Obligations and Disclosure Requirements) Regulations, 2015 (collectively referred to as 'Circulars').
In accordance with the abovementioned Circulars, the Notice of 35th AGM and Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 is being sent only by electronic mode to those Members whose email addresses are registered with the Company/ Depository Participant(s).
The Notice of AGM and Annual Report for the financial year 2025-26 will be available on the website of the Company at www.mymoneysecurities.com, the website of the stock exchange BSE Limited www.bseindia.com and the website of National Securities Depository Limited ("NSDL") (agency for providing the Remote e-Voting facility) - www.evoting.nsdl.com. In compliance with the provisions of Section 108 of the Act and Rule 20 of the Companies (Management and Administration) Rules, 2014, as amended and Regulation 44 of the SEBI Listing Regulations, the Company is pleased to provide the Members, the facility to cast their votes electronically through the Remote E-voting and E-voting during the AGM in respect of all the businesses to be transacted at the AGM. **The Company has engaged the services of NSDL to provide E-voting platform.** The detailed procedure to cast a vote using the e-voting system of NSDL has been described in the Notice of AGM.
All the Members are informed that;
a) the business set out in the Notice calling the AGM may be transacted through by electronic means only.
b) Remote E-voting facility shall commence from Thursday, 24th September, 2026 at 9.00 a.m. and will end on Saturday, 26th September, 2026 at 5.00 p.m. Remote E-voting will not be allowed beyond the aforesaid date and time and the Remote E-voting module shall be disabled by NSDL upon expiry of aforesaid period;
c) Voting rights shall be reckoned on the paid-up value of shares registered in the name of the Member/beneficial owner as on the cut-off date i.e. 20th Sept 2026, 2026;
d) Any person who becomes a Member of the Company after dispatch of this Notice and holding shares on the cut-off date i.e. 20th September, 2026, may obtain the User ID and password for Remote E-voting by sending a request at evoting@nsdl.co.in or info@masserv.com;
e) Members who have cast their vote by remote E-voting may participate in AGM but shall not be entitled to cast vote again through E-voting during the AGM. Members participating in AGM and had not cast their vote through Remote E-voting can cast their vote through E-voting during the AGM.
f) The Members whose names appear in the Register of Members/ list of beneficial owners maintained by the depositories as on the cut-off date i.e. 20th September, 2026, only shall be entitled to avail the facility of Remote E-voting as well as E-voting during AGM;
Since the AGM is being held through VCOAVM, physical attendance of Members has been dispensed with and accordingly, the facility for appointment of proxies by the Shareholders will not be available for the Meeting. However, Corporate Shareholders can authorize representative(s) to attend the Meeting and are requested to send a certified copy of the Board Resolution authorizing their representative or the authority letter or power of attorney of the board of directors or other governing body of the body corporate authorizing their representative to attend and vote on their behalf at the meeting through email at mymoneysecurities@outlook.com and corporate@ligaya@gmail.com
In case you have not registered your email ID with the Company/ Depository, please follow below instructions to register your email ID for obtaining the annual report for FY 2025-26 and login details for e-voting:
Physical Holding Send a request to Registrar and Transfer Agents of the Company, MAS Services Limited and a self-attested copy of the share certificate (Front and Back), PAN Card (Self attested scanned copy of PAN Card), Aadhaar (Self attested scanned copy of Aadhar Card) for registering email address.
Please send your bank detail with original cancelled cheque to our RTA (i.e. MAS Services Limited, T-34 2nd floor, Okhla industrial area Phase-II, New Delhi 110020) alongwith letter mentioning folio no. If not registered at ready.)
PLEASE UPDATE THE SAME ON OR BEFORE 20/09/2026
Demat Holding Please contact your Depository Participant (DP) and register your email address as per the process advised by DP.
PLEASE UPDATE THE SAME ON OR BEFORE 20/09/2026

For Order of the Board
For My Money Securities Limited
Sd/-
Anjali Chopra
Company Secretary
A174453
Date : 05.09.2026
Place : Delhi

**SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd.**
Corporate Off.: 503 & 504, 5th Floor, G-Block, Inspire BKC, BKC Main Road, Bandra Kurla Complex, Bandra (E), Mumbai - 400051.
Regd. Off.: Cornerzone IT Park, Tower B, 1st Floor, No. 111, Mount Poonamallee Road, Porur, Chennai - 600116, TN

POSSESSION NOTICE FOR IMMOVABLE PROPERTY [(Appendix IV) Rule 8(1)]
WHEREAS the undersigned being the Authorized Officer of SMFG India Home Finance Co. Ltd., a Housing Finance Company (duly registered with National Housing Bank (Fully Owned by RBI)) (hereinafter referred to as "SMHFC") under Securitisation and Reconstruction of Financial Assets and Enforcement of Security Interest Act, 2002 (54 of 2002), and in exercise of the powers conferred under Section 13(12) read with Rule 3 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002 issued Demand Notice dated mentioned below under Section 13(2) of the said Act calling upon you being the borrowers (names mentioned below) to repay the amount mentioned in the said notice and interest thereon within 60 days from the date of receipt of the said notice. The borrowers mentioned herein below having failed to repay the amount, notice is hereby given to the borrowers mentioned herein below and to the public in general that the undersigned has **Taken Possession** of the property described herein below in exercise of powers conferred on me under sub-section (4) of Section 13 of the said Act read with Rule 8 of the Security Interest (Enforcement) Rules, 2002. The borrowers mentioned herein in above in particular and the public in general are hereby cautioned not to deal with said property and any dealings with the property will be subject to the charge of "SMHFC" for an amount as mentioned herein under and interest thereon.

Sl. No.	Name of the Borrower(s) / Guarantor(s) LAN	Description of Secured Assets (Immovable Property)	Demand Notice Date & Amt.	Date of Possession
1	LAN :- 610838012137683 1. Sanni Kumar S/o Raju 2. Ramo Devi W/o. Raju 3. Shyam Kumar S/o. Raju	A Residential House Nagor Nigam No. 89, Built On Plot No. 01 Measuring 120 Sq. Yards Or 100 Sq. Meters Consisting of Part of Khasra No. 359, A Residential Plot No. 01, Situated At Shekhpura, Maliyana Pargana, Tehsil & District : Meerut, Uttar Pradesh. Boundaries - East : Plot Of Premwati; West : House of Ramesh; North : House of Uday Ram; South : Rasta 12 Fit Wide.	23.06.2026 Rs. 30,75,272.10 (Rs. Thirty Lakh Seventy Five Thousand Two Hundred Seventy Two & Paise Ten Only) along with interest as on 16.06.2026	07.09.2026

Place : Meerut, Uttar Pradesh
Date : 07.09.2026
Authorized Officer,
SMFG INDIA HOME FINANCE CO. LTD.

**URANIUM CORPORATION OF INDIA LIMITED**
(A Government of India Enterprise)
PO : Jaduguda Mines, Distt.: Singhbhum (East), Jharkhand - 832102.
website www.uraniumcorp.in

ADVERTISEMENT NO. 12/2026
UCIL invites applications from Indian citizens latest by 15-09-2026 for the following post on contract basis :
The eligibility criteria 6 job specifications of the post are as under:

1	POST NAME	Senior Expert(HRM/Administration)
2	NAME OF POST	01(One))
3	REMUNERATION	Category of Employee Retired from CPSE In the Scale of Rs, 1,00,000 - 2,60,000/-(IDA) and above Consolidated Monthly Emoluments Rs. 1,00,000/-(Rs One Lakh) per month
		Retired from Central Govt, in the level 13 i.e. Rs-1,23,100-2,15,900/- CDA) and above Rs. 1,00,000/- minus monthly Basic Pension drawn at the time of retirement from Government service.
4	EIIGIBILTY CRITERIA	a) Age: Not more than 65 years (as on dosing date of receiving application) b) Qualification: Retired Officers having Post Graduate Diploma In Personnel Management and Industrial Relation or MBA(HRM) or MSW from a Government recognized Unversity. Desirable: Candidate having Degree in Law will be preferred Should have retired from the regular post In Government/PSU in the scale of pay of Rs.1,00,000/- 2,60,000/-(IDA) & above or Level 13 Rs. 1,23,100-2,15,900/- (CDA) & above. Post Qualification Experience: Should have minimum 20years of working experience in Government/PSUs/ Autonomous Organization, Experience in the field of HRM/Administration shall be preferred.
5	DUTIES & RESPONSIBILITY	The duties and responsibilities Includes (but not limited to) providing expert opinions on HRM issues, RTI issues, conduct-Discipline and Appeal matters, liaising with Govt. Agencies/ Autonomous Bodies induding Ministries, Employee related legal issues, PSU Policies, Corporate Governance and Adminstrabve matters pertaining to CPSEs.
6	PROCEDURE FOR APPLYING:	Eligible and interested Retired Officers of Govt/PSU may apply online through recruitment portal of UCIL by visiting UCIL website www.uraniumocorp.in for the post of Senior Expert (HRM/Administration) latest by 15.09.2026 without which application will be rejected.

CBC 48134/11/0039/2627



An excavator clears debris as rescue personnel stand near debris during a rescue operation on the second day on Monday



PANKAJ KUMAR

Delhi Police book PG owner for culpable homicide

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Delhi Police have charged Hariram Gupta, the owner of the collapsed Satya Niketan paying guest building, along with others, under three sections of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita after seven people died and five were injured. The case, FIR No 153/26, was registered at South Campus police station under Sections 105, 290, and 125(a). Gupta was arrested on Monday in Bhiwadi, near Gurugram. His wife, Urmila, and son, Mahesh, were also arrested in connection with the case. The most serious charge is under Section 105, which deals with culpable homicide not amounting to murder. Police are not saying the accused meant to kill the students living in Hostel Daze. Instead, the case is based on the idea that the deaths happened because of actions taken with the knowledge that they could cause death, even if there was no intention to kill. This law covers situations in which an old, occupied building is repaired or altered in a way that makes collapse likely. If the court finds that the deaths happened because someone knew the risks, the punishment can be up to ten



Haram Gupta, owner of the Satya Niketan building being taken to South Campus police station in New Delhi on Monday

PTI

years in prison and a fine. If there was intent to cause death or serious injury, the penalty is life in prison or at least 5 to 10 years, plus a fine. Investigators have described the case as one of alleged negligence and endangerment, not a planned killing. Section 290 covers situations like this. It applies to anyone who, while demolishing, repairing, or building, knowingly or carelessly fails to take enough safety measures to prevent the building or any part of it from falling and causing death. Police say renovation was happening on the ground floor, and residents noticed work and water in the basement. This law targets exactly that kind of oversight: performing structural work without proper support, evacuation, or other safety measures while people are still inside. The punishment is lighter-up to six months in jail, a fine of up to ₹5,000, or both. Still, it gives investigators a clear building-safety offence to focus on as they gather evidence about the work, the contractor, the workers, and who gave the orders. Section 125 deals with rash or careless acts that put lives or safety at risk. Police have used clause (a), which applies when someone is hurt. This clause allows for up to 6 months' imprisonment, a fine of up to ₹5,000, or both. The main section also covers cases where no one is hurt, and a more serious clause applies if someone is badly injured, with up to three years in jail and a fine of up to ₹10,000. Five people

were hurt in the collapse, some seriously. Clause (a) is used for those injuries, separate from the seven deaths. Overall, the FIR treats the collapse as a single event with three legal outcomes: deaths that police say were a known risk from unsafe repairs, failure to secure the building during changes, and careless actions that injured survivors. The case is not just against Gupta but also against 'others.' This means anyone found to have directed, done, or benefited from the work, including family members now in custody, could be added. Ownership documents are part of the investigation. The property is in Urmila's name, while the electricity is registered in Hariram's and Mahesh's names. Police say Mahesh managed the building. Investigators need to show not just whose name is on the papers, but who actually controlled the building, who approved the renovation, and who let students stay while the building was being weakened. All three accused are still in custody while police look into contractors, workers, tenancy records, and the order of work that, according to them, turned the student hostel into an unsafe construction site.

Rescuers race against time at hostel collapse

BHASKAR MUKHERJEE
■ New Delhi

The task of saving lives for rescue personnel at the collapsed boys' hostel in Delhi had a razor-thin margin of error-quickly plough through towering concrete slabs to reach survivors and slow down the moment a cavity is found. Every gap could potentially have a breathing person. This is besides navigating through the cramped lanes of Satya Niketan to move in the heavy machinery required for the operation and rushing the rescued to the hospital, all the while keeping an eye on adjacent buildings whose foundation may have been weakened due to the collapse, and controlling the crowd of friends, family and political leaders gathered at the site. After more than 27 hours since the decades-old five-storey building that housed a boys' paying guest accommodation near Delhi University's South Campus came crashing down around 1.30 pm on Sunday, rescuers said the operation was over. Twelve people were taken out, seven of whom have died. Officials confirmed that the operation ended at 5.10 pm on Monday. All debris has been cleared and no further casualties were found, they said. The task for the teams for the entire duration of the rescue operation remained simple but unforgiving: clear the



rubble, search every possible cavity and ensure that no possible survivor was left behind. The first responders were Delhi Police personnel who received a PCR call about it. The immediate challenge was to establish a secure perimeter around the collapsed structure while ensuring that the adjacent building did not pose an additional structural risk. "We had to secure the area to ensure there were no structural concerns involving the adjacent building. More teams were called from different police stations to help those who were trapped. Some locals and students who were close to the area had already started removing debris from the place," the officer said. Officers also called the Delhi Fire Service immediately so they could start helping the police with the rescue operation. As word spread, the narrow lanes around the site quickly filled with people. Many leaders from different political parties, residents, stu-

dents and curious onlookers crowded the area, forcing police personnel to expand the cordon and repeatedly push people back from the debris. Police also had to call paramilitary forces to secure the area and to maintain law and order. The cramped surroundings added another layer of difficulty. Emergency vehicles had to negotiate congested streets, while police personnel simultaneously tried to maintain a passage for ambulances, fire tenders and rescue teams. "We had to keep the onlookers at bay as police teams wanted to make way for ambulances and fire vehicles," another police officer said. Once the area was secured, the rescue effort moved into a more difficult phase -- removing tonnes of concrete while trying to determine where people could be trapped. The Delhi Fire Service rushed five vehicles to the site after receiving information about the collapse. "We

arranged lights and earth-movers so that heavy concrete could be removed immediately," a fire officer said. But heavy machinery, which could clear large quantities of debris in minutes, could not always be used. The moment rescuers suspected that a person could be trapped beneath a section of rubble, the JCB and earth-movers had to be stopped. The operation would then shift from speed to extreme caution, with rescuers manually working through the debris to reach the trapped person without causing further collapse. "The operation becomes slow if a person is trapped. In such a situation, when a person is under debris, we cannot use earth-movers or JCB machines. When we secure the site and the trapped person is removed, we call the JCB again, which gives pace to the operation once again," the officer said. "We always carry oxygen cylinders with us so that we can drop them under the rubble and the trapped person can breathe easily," the officer said. As the hours passed and daylight disappeared, the rescue operation continued under high mast artificial lights. Machinery was brought in to clear heavy sections of the collapsed structure, while exercising caution in case someone was under the debris. (PTI)

Mole, birthmark help mother identify son body in hospital

SHRUTI BHARDWAJ
■ New Delhi

A mole on his neck and a birthmark on his leg were all that helped Akshit's mother identify her 18-year-old son on Monday, a day after the building housing his paying guest accommodation collapsed in southwest Delhi's Satya Niketan. Akshit, a first-year B.Com student at PGDAV College, had returned to Delhi from his hometown on September 5, just two days before the collapse. His mother, Sweta Singh Yadav, had spent days searching for a PG that would give her son basic comforts so he could focus on his studies. But on Monday, instead of

seeing her son return to his room, she arrived at AIIMS to identify his body. "I had visited five or six paying guest accommodations in the area before choosing one for my son. I wanted him to have basic facilities, including an air conditioner and a washing machine, so that he could concentrate on his studies," Sweta told PTI. Akshit's friend Yugank said the college administration informed students that a student staying in the collapsed building was missing, prompting them to rush to the spot. "We first went to the spot and then came to AIIMS. We were just praying that it should not be Akshit," he said. The building, which housed a boys' paying guest accom-



The initial attempt to identify the body yielded no certainty. But when Akshit's mother was brought in, two small identifying marks provided the confirmation the family had been dreading—a mole and a birthmark. The building, which housed a boys' paying guest accom-

modation in Satya Niketan area near Delhi University's South Campus, collapsed around 1.30 pm on Sunday while repair work was underway. Twelve people were rescued from the debris, of whom seven died. The tragedy was made more painful by the fact that

Akshit had apparently noticed a warning sign in the building before the collapse. Yugank said Akshit had earlier mentioned a crack in the building, but it had subsequently been covered. The news sent shockwaves through Akshit's hometown of Katni in Madhya Pradesh, where neighbours and friends remembered him as a young student who had secured admission to the University of Delhi. Sandeep Tripathi, a neighbour of Akshit's family in Katni, said the family learnt about the collapse around 7 pm on Sunday and immediately began making arrangements to reach Delhi. "Last night, at around 7 pm, the colony residents

suddenly received the news that the building where Akshit lived had collapsed. His father, who was in Rajasthan, reached Delhi, while our ward councillor Dabbu Rajak took his mother and sister to Delhi during the night," he told. The family reached Delhi Monday morning and searched for Akshit and gathered information about his whereabouts, but initially could not find any confirmation. "After reaching there at around 9 am, they searched everywhere and gathered information, but could not find anything. Later, when they went to the trauma centre, a mark on Akshit's body helped in identifying him," Tripathi said. (PTI)

Strange sound warned tenants moments before collapse: Victim

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

A strange sound — like water rushing rapidly through a tap — during lunch prompted 19-year-old Nitesh Chib and his friend to rush towards the staircase moments before the building in Delhi's Satya Niketan they lived in collapsed, killing seven. Chib, second-year B.Com student of DU from Jammu, sustained injuries in the collapse and was later rescued from the debris and taken to hospital for treatment. According to his brother, Chib was having his lunch when he heard a sound like water rushing rapidly through a tap and went towards his friend Neeraj's room. "He asked his friend about the sound, but it became louder," his brother said. "They then rushed towards the staircase. Before they could make their way down, the building collapsed," he said, recount-

ing what Chib had told him. Chib was later rescued and taken for treatment, while his family waited anxiously for his recovery. Chib's rent had been paid for three months, his brother said. He is the only earning member of his family, while his father works as a dry-fruit vendor. "If anything had happened to him, how would his family survive?" he added. The building, which housed a boys' paying guest accommodation near Delhi University's South Campus, collapsed around 1.30 pm on Sunday while repair work was underway. A friend, Nakul, said Bawa had come to stay at the PG only a day before the collapse. Before that, he had been staying at a friend's place for more than a month while working on campaign-related activities. He said that the condition of Bawa is critical. Bawa was staying with another student associated with the NSUI, he said.

Students dig through rubble as others film

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The building in Delhi's Satya Niketan had just collapsed. As dust choked the air and cries rose from beneath the rubble, a handful of students rushed to pull the debris with their bare hands, desperately trying to reach those trapped underneath. Just metres away, others stood still, cameras pointed at the wreckage. In those first, frantic minutes, the divide was stark — seven or eight people were trying to rescue, while dozens watched. Witnesses recalled that there were 50 to 60 people at the spot when the building collapsed, with more than three-fourths having seen it happen. Yet, in those crucial initial minutes, only a handful stepped in, while others remained on the periphery — watching and filming. "We were trying to pull out the first person we could see. There was just one person trying to get him out and we needed more hands. You could see people standing around us with



their phones. It was difficult to understand why someone would come so close to the site and still choose to record instead of helping," said Rohan, a Delhi University student who witnessed the collapse. The decades-old building, which housed a boys' paying guest accommodation near Delhi University's South Campus, collapsed around 1.30 pm on Sunday while repair work was under way. The collapse claimed seven lives. Rohan recalled the first few minutes were particularly chaotic as nobody knew how many people were trapped inside or whether the structure was stable. "I saw someone go back

and thought he was getting to help. When he returned, he was recording. We were looking for people who could help us physically, even if it was just pulling someone out. At that point, we needed hands more than anything else," said Aarav, another DU student who was at the spot. Other students and eyewitnesses, who did not wish to be named, said the response around them was a mix of panic, confusion and people trying to capture what was happening on their phones. One of them said the situation became even more frightening when the adjoining building appeared to shake after the collapse.

DUSU Polls: Students seeks safe housing

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

For Delhi University students often forced to make do with PGs in cramped and congested bylanes of the city, the Satya Niketan building collapse that killed seven people has now lent urgency to a basic demand ahead of the DUSU polls — a safe place to stay. As the rescue operation entered its second day on Monday, students who visited the site of the tragedy said it had also exposed wider concerns over the safety of the accommodations they depend on. Student organisations on Monday intensified their demand for accountability after the collapse of a multi-storey Paying Guest (PG) accommodation near Delhi University's South Campus, alleging lapses in construction safety, regulatory oversight and rescue operations. The Akhil Bharatiya Vidyarthi Parishad (ABVP) demanded the resignation of the MCD commissioner over the Satya Niketan building collapse and warned of action within 24 hours, as its



members allegedly vandalised parts of the civic centre during a protest. ABVP karyakartas have been continuously assisting people at the accident site. Expanding its agitation, ABVP has now launched sit-ins and protests across various colleges and campuses of the University of Delhi. "Karyakartas are demanding accountability from the administration for ensuring students' safety and the suspension of the MCD Commissioner. With the resolve of 'No More Satya Niketan,' ABVP has made it clear that no compromise on students' safety will be tolerated. ABVP staged widespread

protests across various colleges in the North, South, Central, East and Kalkaji campuses of the University of Delhi against the Satya Niketan PG tragedy. ABVP National General Secretary Virendra Singh Solanki said, "Accountability must be fixed for everyone responsible for this tragedy arising from negligence on the part of the MCD administration. Our resolve of 'No More Satya Niketan' is clear: no student in Delhi should ever be forced to risk their life by living in an unsafe building. We demand strict action against negligent officials, building owners and all those who have violated safety norms."



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Devotees take part in Sri Siddharoodha Swami Math yatra in Hubballi

India’s global reach growing despite turmoil: Shah

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Panaji

Union Home Minister Amit Shah on Monday said India’s reach in the diplomatic world was increasing and asserted that the country had maintained the momentum of its economic growth despite global geopolitical turmoil.

He said India had concluded nine free trade agreements (FTAs) by 2026, noting wider economic engagement helped the country record GDP growth rate of 7.8 per cent for the first quarter (April-June) of the financial year 2026-27.

Addressing a function organised in Panaji to confer the President’s Colour on the Goa Police, Shah noted the global diplomatic landscape had remained turbulent over the past few years due to the ongoing Russia-Ukraine war and now the conflict involving the US, Iran and the Gulf countries.

He pointed out that Prime Minister Narendra Modi travelled to 22 countries over the past year, while heads of state from around



Union Home Minister Amit Shah receives a memento from Goa Chief Minister Pramod Sawant in Bambolim, Goa

15 countries visited India during the same period.

“At a time when the whole world was grappling with uncertainty over its economic growth because of this (geopolitical) turmoil, we engaged with other countries, presented strategic partnerships and

maintained the momentum of our economic growth,” Shah said. India has entered into concrete agreements in areas such as defence, technology, energy, investment and trade, he stressed.

Shah said India had concluded nine free trade agreements by

2026, while FTAs had been proposed with 38 countries as effective trade arrangements. He said India was pursuing FTAs with the UAE, Australia, the UK, Oman, New Zealand and the European Union with the objective of increasing trade. “This is also one of the reasons why, in the first quarter of this (fiscal) year, our GDP recorded a robust growth of 7.8 per cent,” Shah said.

The Union minister said India had shared its achievements in different fields with the rest of the world and assisted several countries in disaster relief and capacity building. “India has shared its achievements in Digital Public Infrastructure with the world and provided assistance to several countries in the areas of disaster relief and capacity building,” he said. The BJP leader emphasised that it is because of PM Modi’s consistent efforts and global outreach that India’s diplomacy has been able to establish its place firmly in the world today.

“Whatever the issue facing the world, the entire world looks at what the Prime Minister of India has to say and what his perspective is on that issue. After a long time, it is our leader Narendra Modi who has earned this respect for India in the world,” Shah commented. He said Modi envisaged India as a fully developed country by the 100th year of its independence.

“PM Modi has placed before all of us the vision of a developed India by 2047. He has envisioned a developed India that, when the country completes 100 years of independence, will be number one in the world in every field,” Shah stated.

The Union minister recalled that when this vision was put forward, there were many debates and arguments, but gradually, this vision has transformed into a resolve of 140 crore Indians.

“Today, every Indian believes that, yes, on August 15, 2047, our nation will be the best in the world and we will be number one in every field,” he said.

Manipuri musician dies after assault in Delhi’s Kilokari village

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

A 54-year-old Manipuri musician died after a group of delivery workers and dhaba staff allegedly assaulted him when he objected to their shouting and drinking alcohol outside his Kilokari village apartment in the early hours of Monday, officials said.

Police arrested seven men and apprehended one juvenile in the case.

The Sunlight Colony police station received a PCR call regarding the beating of C Vikram Singh, a Manipur native who has been residing in Kilokari village for several years. A preliminary enquiry revealed that Singh, who

belonged to the Meitei community, objected to men creating a nuisance outside his house.

He sustained injuries during the attack, in which the men rained blows and punches on him, police said.

Singh’s son Yaiphaba rushed him to Holy Family Hospital, where he later succumbed to his injuries, they said.

Police initiated an investigation into the circumstances leading to the assault and Singh’s death. The North East Students Society, Delhi University (NESSDU) condoled Singh’s death and described him as a “respected Manipuri musician”.

Well found under demolished mosque debris, ASI begins probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE

■ Saharanpur

An Archaeological Survey of India (ASI) team began examining a well on Monday, found during debris removal following the demolition of a mosque located on the collectorate premises, officials said.

The well, approximately 20 feet deep and 1.5 meters wide, with iron sheets, was discovered beneath the debris on Sunday during removal work, triggering a debate over its antiquity and historical significance.



Delhi cracks down on illegal buildings

However, some locals claimed that the building was nearly 50 years old and was built in the 1970s. Officials said that permission had originally been granted only for a ground-plus-one structure in these resettlement colonies.

The civic body said that the structure had no sanctioned building plan, nor was any complaint against it received. Officials said the area had been developed as a resettlement colony in the 1970s, with small plots allotted to residents.

The CM said the inquiry was under way and added that if negligence by any other officers emerged during the investigation, action would be taken against them as well. The CM said that according to the initial information, the pillars of the old building had weakened and collapsed after water accumulated in its basement, resulting in the entire building collapsing.

“Approximately 80 per cent of the debris has been cleared, with only the basement debris remaining. Water had accumulated in the basement, and the combination of this with ongoing repair work on the old structure led to the collapse,” she said.

The CM said the injured students are receiving proper medical treatment and their parents are receiving updates about them. “The situation is being closely monitored by Health Minister JP Nadda, Home Minister Amit Shah and the prime minister,” she added.

The chief minister also said that the building adjacent to the one collapsed will be demolished. “Residents of the collapsed building and adjacent unsafe buildings have been evacuated. The standing building, which appears extremely dangerous, will be demolished once the debris is cleared,” she said. A structural audit will be conducted of all such buildings, and strict action will follow, she said.

Govt can’t escape liability: Delhi HC...

“The responsibility, prima facie, in our opinion for such mishaps does not lie solely on the owner of the PG hostel. Rather the responsibility goes to the university authorities as also the MCD which is responsible to ensure every single development in Delhi such as construction of a building or repair, etc is carried out strictly in accordance with the building bylaws or other regulations regulating the building’s development,” the bench said.

“The court’s remarks came while issuing notice to the Centre, Delhi Government, MCD, Delhi Police and NHRC on a PIL by law student Aniket Kumar Gupta, seeking urgent medical care and rehabilitation of affected students, Rs 1 crore compensation to the kin of the deceased and preservation of crucial evidence relating to the collapse.

The petition also sought a structural audit of all PG accommodations.

The court directed the authorities to file their replies within 10 days and listed the matter on September 25.

It noted the assurance given by Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, representing the Centre, Delhi Government, MCD and Delhi Police, that the rescue operation is being carried out in full swing and no stone will be left unturned.

The court noted that the PIL has been filed in the wake of the “most unfortunate incident” that happened on Sunday in Satya Niketan locality. It said many of the affected students have been taken to hospital and others are still presumably lying inside the debris crying for help and their lives.

The court directed that the MCD at the highest executive level should take up the issue and get an enquiry conducted as to whether the buildings which collapsed in the incident were constructed as per any valid permission or not.

“If it is found that the buildings were construct-

ed without valid permission, the MCD shall fix the responsibility of the officials concerned for such lapse. “MCD shall also prepare a report indicating whether the buildings in which PG hostels are housed have been constructed in terms of requisite permission and whether there has been any violation to such permissions or building bylaws. The report shall also include how many students are residing in these PG hostels,” the bench said.

It noted that the buildings that collapsed housed students studying in DU-affiliated colleges and many of them were from other cities.

The bench noted that DU does not provide adequate hostel facilities to its outstation students, due to which the students and their parents are constrained to take shelter in these PG hostels.

The court directed the MCD to explain in its affidavit whether there are any statutory or executive regulations in place regulating the PG hostels. It asked DU to indicate in its response how many outstation students take admission in colleges affiliated to it and how many hostels are being run by it or the Government.

The bench asked Mehta to impress upon the Government to provide hostel facility to students, which the law officer said appeared to be the root cause of the incident.

“It is not only very dangerous but they are causing threat to the lives, security of these students. This is because of absolutely inadequate number of hostels. In Delhi, students from all over the country come to study. That’s the reputation these institutions enjoy,” it said.

The court said if the authorities invest in such measures, they are investing in children who are the future of the country.

“It is a very pathetic situation so far as the number of hostels run by the Government and universities is concerned. Some statutory mechanism should be put in place to regulate these PGs. These PG owners recklessly indulge in construction. If the permission is for two-storey building, the construction is made for six, foundation remains the same and this collapse is probably a result of such construction,” it remarked.

“There were 50 young students who were at the threshold of entering their lives and seven of them have died. Majority of them are perhaps still lying under the debris, there can’t be anything more sad than this. You (Government) can’t escape your responsibility,” the bench said, adding that every second year such incidents are happening.

Mehta and the petitioner’s counsel flagged concerns about videos being circulated on social media showing persons injured or trapped under the debris and urged the court to issue directions stopping the circulation of such sensitive videos.

“Death can’t be sensationalised. No tragedy can be sensationalised,” Mehta said.

Satya Niketan PG owner, wife, son arrested

The investigators noted that the Satya Niketan property was registered in Urmila’s name, while the electricity connection was in the names of Hariram and Mahesh. According to the police, Mahesh was in charge of the day-to-day management of the building.

An FIR was filed at the South Campus police station pursuant to sections 105, 290 and 125 of the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, which cover culpable homicide not amounting to murder, negligent conduct in the repair or construction of buildings and an act endangering life or personal safety. A lookout circular was issued, and his passport details were obtained to prevent him from leaving the country. Search operations were carried out at various addresses in Delhi, Gurugram, and Uttar Pradesh by 10 teams drawn from the district police, the Special Staff, and other units.

Delhi Police teams carried out raids on suspected hideouts and travelled to Sector 23 in

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Gurugram, where Gupta has been running Hariram Paints and Hardware for approximately 15 years. People in the area said the shop had been locked for two days. The locals referred to him as a long-established hardware dealer who owns several properties in both Sector 23 and Palam Vihar.

The current investigation focuses on questions of ownership, control, and the work underway at the time the building failed. The police are looking into who authorised the repairs and renovations in the basement and on the ground floor, whether the work was legal, and whether the water that collected in the basement following the recent rain weakened the foundations.

They are also investigating who leased the premises for use as a boys’ PG, who received the rent, and how many people were living in the building at the time it collapsed. A key area of inquiry is the difference between the building as it was planned and the building that actually stood on the 55-square-yard plot. According to civic records referred to by the investigators, there was no approved plan for the multi-storey building that eventually occupied the site, that altering the basement of an existing building is considered hazardous, and that extra floors were beyond what the resettlement colony was allowed to have.

The investigating officer (IO) is also reviewing previous statements that claimed relatives of people associated with the neighbouring plots had taken part in running or looking after the property.

The documents retrieved so far, such as the tenancy records, are being cross-referenced with municipal and electricity records. Gupta’s movements after Sunday afternoon, when the shop was closed, and after he left Gurugram, constitute a separate aspect of the case, a police official said.

The collapse is being attributed to alleged negligence in the maintenance and modification of an occupied building. The police State that responsibility will be determined not just for the deaths but also for allowing the students to stay in the building while work was going on below. Gupta, Urmila and Mahesh are still in custody as the investigation continues.

Nandigram heads to bypoll

He defeated Trinamool Congress chief Banerjee in her Bhabanipur stronghold by 15,105 votes and subsequently chose to retain the Kolkata seat, resigning as the MLA from Nandigram. He had also defeated Banerjee in Nandigram in the 2021 Assembly polls.

The other West Bengal seat headed for a bypoll is Rejinagar, which was vacated by Aam Janata Unnayan Party (AJUP) chief Humayun Kabir.

Kabir, a former Trinamool Congress leader who floated the AJUP after his expulsion from the party, won both Rejinagar and Naoda in the 2026 Assembly elections.

In Tamil Nadu, bypolls will be held in the Madurantakam (SC) and Dharapuram (SC) Assembly constituencies, which were won in the recent elections by AIADMK’s Maragatham Kumaravel and P Sathyabama, respectively.

The two were among a group of rebel AIADMK legislators who backed Chief Minister Vijay’s Tamilaga Vettri Kazhagam (TVK) Government in a floor test. Kumaravel and Sathyabama later resigned as MLAs and joined the ruling TVK, necessitating the bypolls.

Puducherry’s Thattanchavady seat was vacated by Chief Minister and All India N R Congress chief N Rangasamy, who had won from both Thattanchavady and Mangalam in the Assembly elections. Rangasamy opted to retain Mangalam and resigned from Thattanchavady.

The Model Code of Conduct has come into

force with immediate effect in the districts concerned, the EC said.

Two other Lok Sabha seats — Shillong in Meghalaya and Basirhat in West Bengal — remain vacant and polls have not been scheduled there yet.

Shillong fell vacant following the death of Voice of the People Party (VPP) MP Ricky Andrew J Syngkon in February this year, while Basirhat has remained vacant since the death of Trinamool Congress MP Haji Sheikh Nurul Islam in September 2024.

Malaysia Airlines, AI Express flights diverted...

In view of the issue, a “local standby was declared” at Chennai airport, and the necessary emergency response arrangements were kept ready. The aircraft landed safely and vacated the runway under its own power.

Following the declaration of a local standby, the airport’s operational and emergency agencies were kept on alert, with necessary arrangements put in place to facilitate the aircraft’s safe arrival. The airline’s engineering and technical teams are assessing the reported technical issue. “All operations are normal,” the official added.

Doon court acquits Balkrishna in forged...

However, the court found major gaps in the evidence. It held that scanned copies of the educational certificates produced by the CBI were not admissible because the required legal procedure for electronic evidence was not followed.

The court also gave little credence to the Central Forensic Science Laboratory handwriting report, noting that the expert had acknowledged limitations in comparing photocopies. Besides, some prosecution witnesses were also found unreliable, while one key witness had turned hostile. The order stated that Balkrishna and Dwivedi are currently on bail, but the bail bonds furnished by them would be cancelled.

SC rejects Aravalli panel extension

In its plea, the apex court-appointed Aravalli HPC asked the top court to extend the deadline for submission of its final report by six months, saying it needs more time for a “comprehensive and defensible” assessment of the Aravalli range. The bench said that the committee must hear all stakeholders, including tribal communities in Rajasthan and Gujarat, and may submit issue-specific interim reports to enable the court to resolve urgent questions separately.

The court then listed the matter for December 2. On December 28 last year, amid a row over the definition of Aravalli hills approved by it, the top court took suo motu cognisance of the issue. The committee, constituted through an order dated May 25, has been conducting an independent review of the Centre’s report on the definition and delineation of the Aravallis.

The deadline for the panel’s final report was August 31. In its compliance report submitted on August 31, the committee said it needs to bring together spatial, ecological, geological, hydrological, socio-economic, and stakeholder evidence before arriving at its conclusions regarding the Aravallis.

“The committee has... reached the view that additional time is necessary to complete the scientific process of geospatial assessment, sensitivity analysis, expert examination, field and stakeholder validation, and synthesis required for a comprehensive and defensible

report,” said the panel in its compliance report.

It has urged the top court to extend the deadline for submission of the final report to February 28, 2027.

In its compliance report, the panel says the issues regarding Aravallis extend beyond technical delineation and cannot be properly addressed through a “single terrain-based criterion or a single source of evidence.”

The matter originated from the Supreme Court’s November 20, 2025 ruling on mining activities in the Aravalli region. A Bench headed by then Chief Justice of India B R Gavai approved an elevation-based criterion suggested by an expert committee to identify the Aravalli Hills and Range for the purposes of regulating mining.

Under the formula accepted by the court, a landform in the Aravalli districts would qualify as an Aravalli Hill if it rose at least 100 metres above the surrounding local terrain. Two or more such hills located within a distance of 500 metres were to be treated as part of the Aravalli Range. The court endorsed restrictions on mining in core and ecologically sensitive areas but stopped short of imposing a blanket prohibition. It reasoned that an outright ban could instead encourage unauthorised mining and result in the criminalisation of activities that could otherwise be regulated.

The definition subsequently came under intense criticism, with environmentalists and other stakeholders arguing that the elevation-based test could exclude a substantial portion of the Aravallis from legal protection.

There were concerns that more than 90 per cent of the region could effectively fall outside the safeguards and become vulnerable to mining. Amid the controversy, the top court revisited the issue. On December 29, 2025, a bench headed by CJI Surya Kant put the November 20 ruling on hold and suspended the implementation of the earlier expert committee’s recommendations.

The bench observed that several of the concerns surrounding the judgment appeared to arise from uncertainty or lack of clarity in the directions issued by the Court. It also indicated that a fresh, independent assessment of the ecological consequences of the proposed demarcation may be necessary.

The court thereafter decided to constitute a new expert body to examine the issue afresh and recommend an appropriate methodology for identifying and defining the Aravalli Hills and Range.

Defence ministry clears ₹1.1 lakh crore...

The trawl tanks and bridge system will be utilised to provide composite crossings to fighting formations during operations in varied terrains,” the ministry said.

For the Indian Navy, AoN was accorded for the procurement of Arudhra radars, design and development and subsequent procurement of Marine Gas Turbines (MGT).

Arudhra radars will replace the existing Air Route surveillance radars at various Naval Air Stations, and MGT, a warship propulsion system, is expected to reduce dependency on foreign vendors. For the Indian Air Force, approval was granted to various proposals to enhance the war-fighting capability of fighters, transports and helicopters. Approval was accorded for procuring Ground-Based Multi-Purpose Jammer (GBMPJ) and installing Defence Forces Secure Access Card system, according to the ministry.

The GBMPJ will provide effective jamming against radars of adversaries, it said in a statement. Of the total AoNs accorded, approximately 98 per cent of procurements will be made from the Indian industry, it added.

Congress attacks BJP on Delhi building collapse

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a scathing attack against the BJP over the Satya Niketan PG building collapse, the Congress on Monday alleged that Prime Minister Narendra Modi's "PR balloon" had been deflated and termed the "four-engine Government" in Delhi a killing machine claiming the lives of students. Leader of Opposition in Lok Sabha Rahul Gandhi accused the BJP Government of evading accountability for the collapse and alleged that Prime Minister Modi uses insulting labels like "dimagi Naxal" and "naraaz phoopha" against those who ask questions.

The remarks came a day after the five-storey building in the congested area near Delhi University's South Campus collapsed killing seven people.

The opposition party demanded that action be taken against all those responsible. It also demanded that affordable accommodation be provided to students, a rent control act be brought for hostels and PGs and Rs 1 crore compensation be given to the family of those who have lost their lives.

Gandhi asked what the excuse for this helplessness was when Delhi has a "triple-engine" Government, saying it stems from a lack of intent.



"There is no accountability," Gandhi said in his post in Hindi on X, using the hashtag "TINA". Supporters of the prime minister often cite the "TINA" factor — There Is No Alternative — to argue that Modi is the only capable and indispensable leader for India.

The former Congress chief claimed that every time, the BJP Government follows the same shameful pattern -- no prevention before accidents, just grandstanding after them, and pinning the blame on a few low-level officers, while the real culprits remain unaccountable.

"The collapse of the building packed with students at Satya Niketan is no isolated tragedy. In the last four months, six people died in a similar disaster in Saidulajab, and a fire in Hauz Rani claimed 22 lives.

"Every time, lives, dreams, and aspirations get buried under rubble -- and every

time, any real action is nowhere to be found. And when you demand accountability, the prime minister himself slaps you with insulting labels like 'dimagi Naxal and naraaz phoopha' — the intent being to shame, defame, and silence anyone who dares to ask questions," he said.

For 12 years, this Government has spun people around with lofty talk about the whole world, but never addressed the real issues, Gandhi claimed.

Delhi has a "triple-engine" Government, so what is the excuse for this helplessness now, he asked. "The helplessness stems from a lack of intent — because where there's no intent, there's no accountability either."

Addressing a press conference along with NSUI president Vinod Jakhar, Congress leader Kanhaiya Kumar said it is unfortunate that there is no clarity even after 24 hours

and the debris has not yet been fully cleared.

"There is no information on how many people are still trapped under the debris. The PG had 45 beds, it was Sunday, what if all the students were there? There were labourers working in the basement and students sit on the building's steps as well. The police administration present there is not only failing to carry out relief and rescue operations properly, but is also engaged in the task of hiding the truth," the NSUI in-charge said.

He alleged that the BJP has constructed five-star party offices in every district which don't collapse, but bridges fall, roads break, and Government buildings collapse. "There are such incidents where students have lost their lives. In one place, a fire broke out in a coaching centre. In another, a library flooded with water. In yet another, a student died from an electric shock. The question is-when will the BJP Government take responsibility and accountability for this?" Kumar asked.

Prime Minister Modi -- who addressed students at Delhi University's Shri Ram College of Commerce on Saturday - has time to send congratulatory messages to Italian Premier Georgia Meloni but no time to visit Satya Niketan to express his condolences, he said.

Hooch tragedy toll in MP rises to 12

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Sagar (MP)

The death toll in the Sagar hooch tragedy in Madhya Pradesh rose to 12 on Monday after one more person succumbed, while nearly 30 others remained under medical observation, including two in critical condition, officials said.

Police have arrested 14 of the 30 persons named as accused in FIRs lodged in connection with the incident as authorities launched a major crackdown on bootleggers, they said.

Three separate FIRs have been registered on complaints by the victims' kin, Sagar Range Deputy Inspector General of Police Shashindra Chouhan said.

On Sunday, 11 persons died and 54 others fell ill after allegedly consuming spurious liquor in two villages of Banda tehsil, about 30 km from the Sagar district headquarters.

Many of those who fell ill complained of symptoms like blurred vision and dizziness.

One more person died in the early



hours of Monday, raising the toll to 12, Sagar Collector Pratibha Pal said.

She said that 25 to 30 persons were under medical observation and two of them were in critical condition.

One of the sick persons was airlifted to Bhopal on Sunday for advanced medical treatment, she said.

Fourteen of the 30 accused named in the FIRs have been arrested, and a hunt is on for the remaining suspects, Pal said.

Police and the excise department launched a massive crackdown on bootleggers after gathering inputs,

she said, adding that revenue department teams, along with village representatives, were going door-to-door to check whether people were possessing liquor bottles.

The police were also investigating a suspected link between people in Lalitpur in neighbouring Uttar Pradesh and the local liquor contractor (outlet owner), Chouhan said.

Collector Pal on Sunday said the preliminary investigation indicated that the liquor had been supplied from Lalitpur.

"There is a gang in Lalitpur that supplies this kind of poisonous liquor. Since this area is adjacent to Uttar Pradesh, this has come to light in the preliminary investigation," she said.

The administration has appealed to people who consumed liquor and were experiencing symptoms such as vomiting, headache or fever to immediately visit health centres and undergo medical examination.

Authorities suspended three excise officials and two police personnel in connection with the tragedy.

ED raids premises linked to Urdu daily promoted by TMC MP

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Kolkata

The Enforcement Directorate on Monday raided premises in Kolkata, Delhi and Ranchi as part of a money laundering investigation against an Urdu daily promoted by TMC Rajya Sabha MP Nadimul Haque, officials said.

The 56-year-old Haque, who is also a journalist and businessman, is the director of the company (Akhbar-E-Mashriq Pvt Ltd) that brings out the daily named Akhbar-E-Mashriq.

There was no immediate response on the ED action from Haque or the TMC.

The probe relates to allegations of publication and dissemination of material

promoting communal disharmony, unaccounted cash transactions and funding from suspicious sources of the daily, the officials said.

About seven premises in Kolkata, Delhi and Ranchi (Jharkhand) were raided.

The ED case booked under the Prevention of Money Laundering Act (PMLA) stems from an FIR registered by the Bidhannagar Police Commissionerate, they said.

"Akhbar-e-Mashriq is more than a newspaper. It is a four-decade legacy of uncompromising journalism, technological innovation, and relentless dedication to our readers," the Urdu daily states on its website.

LPG refill booking interval will be same for urban, rural areas: Suresh Gopi



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

Union Minister Suresh Gopi on Monday said that the Union Government has asked the oil marketing companies to uniformly implement the revised LPG refill booking interval of 25 days in both urban and rural areas immediately.

Gopi, the Union Minister of State for Petroleum, Natural Gas and Tourism, said in a Facebook post that due to the pressure on LPG supply in the wake of the Middle East conflict, the refill booking interval was 25 days in urban areas and 45 days in rural areas.

"However, in view of the current LPG supply situation improving and the significant reduction in refill backlog, the central Government has relaxed this restriction. Now, all domestic LPG consumers, regardless of urban or rural, can book refills at an interval of 25 days," he said.

West Bengal economy to revive in 1 year: Suwendu

SAUGAR SENGUPTA ■ Kolkata

Bengal's economic health had just started to limp back to normalcy, but it would be at least a year before it regains its vitality, thanks to the economic anarchy and large-scale corruption of the previous Trinamool Congress regime, State Chief Minister Suwendu Adhikari on Monday said.

"Though it cannot be said that the economic health of our State has recovered fully, it has started recovering, and I am of the opinion that in a year's time we will be able to overcome the crisis," Adhikari said, holding the previous Mamata Banerjee Government fully responsible for the "economic mess" that Bengal was in.

"There was large-scale corruption and fiscal indiscipline committed by the previous Government," and adding insult to injury, the previous Government would not join the central Government's schemes leading to the present situation, the Chief Minister alleged. "The State Government has joined the various central schemes as a result of which more funds are coming ... I am hopeful that the economy will return to normalcy in a year," he said and claimed that because of some corrective measures taken by the Government revenue leakages would stop.

"The Government has taken some measures that will plug the revenue leakages" and eventually the



State's tax revenue would go up by 18 per cent, he said.

The Chief Minister was addressing a gathering of beneficiaries of social schemes where old people and widows had assembled to receive enhanced benefits.

The State Government increased the old age allowance from Rs 1,000 to Rs 1,500. The Chief Minister said that the waiting lists of beneficiaries prepared by the previous Government would stand cancelled as new welfare camps would be set up by the new Government to enlist newer beneficiaries.

Meanwhile, in a new development, the Central and State agencies have approved construction of a four-lane greenfield corridor connecting parts of North Bengal so that vehicles moving from southern Bengal to northern Bengal will not have to enter the Kishanganj corridor of Bihar, sources said. The new road would connect Chopra in North Dinajpur with parts of Darjeeling district.

India-France ties have reached new heights: PM Modi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi has said India-France relations have reached new heights, and this strategic partnership is particularly special because it rests on the solid foundation of long-standing cultural and political ties.

Addressing virtually the inauguration of the Swaminarayan temple in Paris on Sunday, Modi hoped that the grand temple in Paris will stand for centuries as a symbol of cooperation and opportunity between both nations.

"In recent years, relations between India and France have reached new heights. Together with my friend, President (Emmanuel) Macron, both nations are building a Special Global



Strategic Partnership," he said.

The prime minister said that from technology, AI, and defence to space and climate action, India and France are moving forward together with new momen-

tum and energy.

"We are also celebrating 2026 as the India-France Year of Innovation. This strategic partnership is particularly special because it rests on the solid foundation of our long-standing cultur-

al and political ties," he said.

Modi said these days, there is much talk about joint venture possibilities between India and France.

He said history bears witness that the sacrifice of Indian soldiers in France remains alive in the hearts of people to this day.

"Language enthusiasts also know the pivotal role French scholars played in popularising Sanskrit. Romain Rolland's writings on Ramakrishna Paramahansa and Swami Vivekananda brought our societies closer," he said.

Furthermore, the prime minister said, the spiritual journey of 'The Mother' from Paris to the Sri Aurobindo Ashram in Puducherry has inspired countless Indian and French seekers.

He said decades ago, Srila Prabhupada Swami also

MPSC paper leak: Aspirants protest in Pune

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Pune

A large number of MPSC aspirants staged a protest march in Pune on Monday, demanding transparency in the recruitment process and action against the alleged paper leaks and irregularities in various examinations.

The protesters demanded the resignation of the Maharashtra Public Service Commission (MPSC) chairman and secretary and the immediate appointment of officers with a "clean image" to the posts.

The march began at Omkareshwar Temple Chowk and proceeded to the Pune District Collectorate, where pro-



testers raised demands related to the functioning of the MPSC and examination procedures.

NCP (SP) MLA Rohit Pawar and Congress legislator Vishwajit Kadam joined the protesters, extending support to their demands. Pawar said

the Government must fulfil the protesters' demands. The protesters demanded that the commission provide, within eight days, an explanation on objections raised about the Drug Inspector (Group-B) examination and initiate an inquiry into alleged irregularities.

Among other demands, the aspirants sought an inquiry into alleged errors in the evaluation of descriptive papers of the 2025 State Services Main Examination and Agricultural Services examination. They also demanded that the preliminary inquiry report submitted by the Mumbai Crime Branch to the MPSC be made public.

CM Mohan Yadav meets UAE economy minister in Dubai

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Dubai

Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav on Monday held a high-level meeting with UAE Cabinet member and Minister of Economy and Tourism Abdullah bin Touq Al Marri in Dubai, seeking to deepen investment and economic cooperation between the UAE and Madhya Pradesh.

Yadav formally invited Al Marri to participate in the upcoming Global Investors Summit (GIS) in Madhya Pradesh. Accepting the invitation, Al Marri assured him that a special investment delegation from Dubai would soon visit Madhya Pradesh to explore opportunities in the hotel and



Madhya Pradesh Chief Minister Mohan Yadav interacts with global investors and industrial leaders in Dubai

PTI

hospitality sector.

The two sides also discussed potential cooperation in mining, textiles, forestry and tourism. Yadav outlined the state Government's transparent policies, land ownership regulations, labour reforms and investor pro-

tection mechanisms. He also highlighted the positive experience of UAE companies already operating in Madhya Pradesh and reiterated the Government's commitment to providing a conducive business environment for new investors.

Indian, Chinese armies hold talks on border



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Indian and Chinese armies reviewed the situation along the Line of Actual Control (LAC) in the Arunachal Pradesh sector, days after the two sides held Special Representative talks in Beijing on the festering boundary question.

The focus of the corps commander-level talks at the Wacha-Damai border meeting point in Arunachal Pradesh's Kibithoo region on Sunday was to maintain peace and tranquillity along the frontier, people familiar with the matter said.

The Indian delegation was headed by Lt General Girish Kalia, the commander of the Army's Dimapur-based 3 Corps. There is no official word yet on the talks.

The meeting also came amid reports of aggressive military posturing by Chinese troops along the LAC in the Upper Subansiri region of Arunachal Pradesh.

In the Special Representative (SR) talks on August 25, India conveyed

to China the importance of maintaining peace and tranquillity along the frontier for overall bilateral ties.

National Security Advisor Ajit Doval held the SR talks with Chinese Foreign Minister Wang Yi which focused on delimitation of the frontier and sustaining work on trans-boundary cooperation.

In his remarks at the meeting, Doval said that normalcy in the ties has been a direct result of both sides maintaining peace and tranquillity in the border areas.

The Indian side highlighted the importance of maintaining peace and tranquillity in the India-China border areas for the continued development and progress of the bilateral relationship, the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) had said on the SR talks.

Both Doval and Wang are the designated SRs for the boundary talks mechanism, which was established in 2003 to comprehensively address the dispute over the India-China border spanning 3,488 km.

States Focus



VP RADHAKRISHNAN TO VISIT ARUNACHAL PRADESH

Vice President CP Radhakrishnan will arrive in Itanagar on Tuesday evening on a two-day visit to Arunachal Pradesh, during which he will attend a special session of the Assembly, officials said.

Radhakrishnan is on a four-day tour of Assam, Meghalaya, Manipur and Arunachal Pradesh, which kicked off on Sunday. The vice president will arrive in Itanagar from Manipur's Imphal on Tuesday evening and attend a special session of the Arunachal Pradesh Legislative Assembly the next day, officials said. He will also visit the Assembly gallery-cum-museum. Radhakrishnan's itinerary also includes visits to Nyedra Namlo (Prayer Hall), the Jawaharlal Nehru State Museum and the Donyi Polo Mission School for the Hearing and Visually Impaired in Itanagar, they said. (PTI)



COMMITTED TO TRANSFORMING MIZORAM INTO DIGITAL STATE: CM

Chief Minister Lalduhoma on Monday said he is committed to transforming Mizoram into a "digital state" with an aim to make governance efficient and services more accessible.

Lalduhoma was speaking at the launch of a series of technology-driven initiatives at the Administrative Training Institute (ATI) here, including the Smart ATI App, Smart Classroom and Digital Learning Laboratory.

"My personal vision and goal is to make Mizoram a digital state. Mizoram is well-positioned to embrace digital governance, given its relatively small population and high literacy rate," the chief minister said. (PTI)

Punjab Police bust cross-border camera spy racket

PRAMOD KUMAR SINGH
■ New Delhi/Chandigarh

The shoe shop, which was set up on the road between Ludhiana and Ferozepur, appeared completely ordinary. It opened at irregular times, and two Chinese cameras were directed not towards the cash register but at the highway, six kilometres from Baddowal Cantonment. The login IDs and passwords crossed the border, and live images of Army and paramilitary movements were transmitted. This shop is now one element in a bigger scheme.

Over the last six months, the Punjab Police have dealt with five cases in which internet cameras were used for spying. They arrested 22 of the 23 suspects and seized 11 cameras, solar panels, SIM cards, mobile phones, a router, and an adapter. Eight

first information reports were filed in Kapurthala, Amritsar, Bathinda, Pathankot, Barnala, and Ludhiana under the Official Secrets Act and the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita.

Investigators are now tracking SIM serial numbers, device IDs, cloud logins, and financial transactions. This method is inexpensive, difficult to trace, and easy to deny. Solar-powered 4G cameras that do not require wiring are mounted on poles, shop awnings, and highways. These cameras monitor cantonments, logistics routes, and railway lines. Residents are paid tens of thousands of rupees to install the cameras and provide the login details.

Handlers in Pakistan view the camera feeds through a phone app. If a feed stops working, they send someone to fix the equipment. Payments have increased as their operations have expand-



Representative image

ed. For example, a recruit from Pathankot to Jammu via NH-44 earned about ₹40,000 and received instructions from a contact in Dubai. In Kapurthala, an installer was paid ₹35,000 by a handler known as "Fauji."

In Ludhiana, Rashpal Singh from Gurdaspur, his uncle Akash, and two men from Amritsar, Varinder Masih and

Rohit, reportedly received ₹3 to 4 lakh over several months, with the money sent through hawala. Recruitment happened through Instagram and with help from a fixer in Punjab, who connected local recruits with ISI desks in Dubai. The cameras themselves show the supply chain: many are banned Chinese internet models that are still being cir-

PM Modi to unveil ₹35,000 crore projects in Vadodara

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Prime Minister Narendra Modi will lay foundation stones, inaugurate and dedicate to the nation development projects worth more than ₹35,000 Crore in Vadodara on Tuesday. He will also inaugurate the Global Fintech Fest (GFF) 2026, one of the world's largest and most influential annual fintech conferences in Mumbai.

Modi will first visit Vadodara, where he will lay the foundation stone and inaugurate and dedicate to the nation various development projects. He will also address the gathering, an official statement said.

Among the projects the prime minister will dedicate to the nation are three important sections of the Western Dedicated Freight Corridor



(WDFC), covering 326 route km and developed at a cost of more than ₹20,700 crore. These include the Sanand (N)-Makarpura, New Umbergaon-New Saphale and New Saphale-JNPT sections.

The direct connectivity of Jawaharlal Nehru Port Authority (JNPA) will facilitate faster movement of EXIM cargo, strengthen connectivity between industrial centres and ports, reduce logistics costs and help decongest Mumbai's railway network.

With the commissioning of these sections, the Dedicated Freight Corridor (DFC) network will stand fully operational across its entire length.

The Prime Minister will also flag off freight train services from New Sanand (North), New Makarpura, New Umbergaon and New JNPT, Mumbai.

In addition, he will flag off a new train service between Vadodara and Tanda Road, benefiting the people of Vadodara, Chhota Udepur

and Alirajpur districts.

Modi will lay the foundation stone for three railway projects spanning 329 km and costing more than ₹9,700 crore. These include the Vadodara-Ratlam third and fourth lines, Miyagam Karjan-Choranda-Malsar gauge conversion and the Vishwamitri-Dabhoi doubling project.

He will lay the foundation stone for three national highway projects costing around ₹1,780 crore. Modi will also lay the foundation stone for and inaugurate various Gujarat Government projects worth around ₹2,600 crore.

In Mumbai, the prime minister will inaugurate the Global Fintech Fest (GFF) 2026, one of the world's largest and most influential annual fintech conferences. The seventh edition of the Global Fintech Fest is being held from September 8 to 11.

33% reservation will unlock new avenues for women: Om Birla



Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla inaugurates All-India Capacity Building Workshop on Gender-Responsive Governance in Faridabad on Monday. NCW Chairperson Vijaya Rahatkar was also present. PIONEER PHOTO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Lok Sabha Speaker Om Birla on Monday described the 33 per cent reservation for women in the Lok Sabha and State Legislative Assemblies as a historic necessity, asserting that the coming years will witness a new generation of female leaders across political, administrative, and social spheres. He stated that the day is not far when women will account for more than 50 per cent of public services.

Inaugurating a two-day All-India Capacity Building Workshop on "Gender-Responsive Governance" organised by the National Commission for Women (NCW) in Faridabad, Birla emphasised that the focus must now shift from merely providing support and opportunities to enabling women to actively shape policies, programmes, and laws.

Birla stressed that women legislators across the Lok Sabha, State Assemblies, Panchayats, and Municipalities can play a decisive role in ensuring legislation responds to ground-level realities. Highlighting the constitutional commitment to equality and legislative mea-

sures for women's safety, self-reliance, and empowerment, he added that institutions like the NCW play a vital role in identifying emerging challenges and facilitating solutions.

Underlining economic and social empowerment as non-negotiable for national progress, the Speaker noted that India cannot achieve its goal of becoming a developed nation without empowering women, who constitute nearly half the population. He urged women legislators to deliberate on effective policies and schemes to strengthen women economically, particularly those facing deprivation, while calling for cross-legislative sharing of best practices and enhanced legal awareness in vulnerable areas.

Birla observed that sensitivity is a core strength of women's leadership, fostering deeper understanding and a responsive work culture to address social challenges.

The event was attended by NCW Chairperson Vijaya Rahatkar, Haryana Minister of State (IC) for Food, Civil Supplies & Consumer Affairs Rajesh Nagar, and around 200 women legislators representing 20 States and 2 Union Territories.

Suvendu announces ₹1 lakh grant for Durga Puja in West Bengal

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari on Monday announced a grant of ₹1 lakh to the Durga Puja committees, which is about ₹10,000 less than the previous year. This, besides waiving electricity charges by 100 per cent.

Appealing to the big-budget puja committees to forego their claim to Government grant, Adhikari said, "those Puja committees which are capable of funding their Pujas independently are called upon to waive their claim to the grants."

The Government will organise a Puja-centric programme at the iconic Eden Gardens on Mahalaya day, which Prime Minister Narendra Modi was likely to attend, Adhikari said, adding the programme would include drone and firework displays.



West Bengal Chief Minister Suvendu Adhikari interacts with West Bengal DGP Siddh Nath Gupta during a coordination and security review meeting for the upcoming Durga Puja festival in Kolkata on Monday. PTI

The Chief Minister, who announced a two-day State-funded programme before the Pujas, said: "From now on it will be ensured that no Puja committee has to go to the High Court to seek permission to organise Pujas."

The Chief Minister also announced that prizes would be given to the best Pujas based on decoration, theme, idol, environmental friendliness, etc.

Apparently criticising his predecessor Mamata Banerjee for inaugurating the Durga Pujas before the commencement of the Devi Paksha, he said, "the Government will not allow inauguration of Pujas before Devi Paksha or Matri Paksha sets in ... Unlike on previous occasions ... When the Pujas were inaugurated on Pitri Paksha before the Mahalayas which is not auspicious for

our Dharma."

The Chief Minister also put a ban on the organisation of Pujas blocking the national highways and main thoroughfares. "No national highway will be blocked, and there will be a ban on organising Pujas on 13 main thoroughfares of Kolkata including Red Road, Jawaharlal Nehru Road, Khidderpore Road, DL Khan Road... Besides, liquor sale will also be banned on Ashtami Day when Pushpanjali is offered ... The idols should also not be designed defying the traditional aesthetics of the Sanatan dharma, he said, adding that no DJ would be played during the immersion processions.

The Government servants who would be involved in the Durga Puja management during the festivities would be given two days' paid leave after the Pujas, he said.

Calcutta HC quashes arrest warrant against Mahua

SAUGAR SENGUPTA
■ Kolkata

There was a big relief for Trinamool Congress MP Mahua Moitra when the Calcutta High Court on Monday quashed the arrest warrant against her, issued by a Krishnagar district court, and transferred her case to the special MP-MLA court in Bidhannagar, Kolkata.

The order was passed by the Division Bench of Justice Debangshu Basak and Justice Aryan Dutta.

The district court had, on August 19, issued an arrest warrant against Moitra for not appearing before it despite repeated summons. The TMC leader was summoned after FIRs were lodged against her for allegedly hurting the religious sentiments of some



community.

Moitra had earlier contended that it was becoming difficult for her to appear before the court because of security reasons, as members of the BJP were blocking her path and she feared an attack from them. She had reminded the court of how the TMC leaders were being attacked, and eggs were hurled at them in public.

J&K International Film Festival kicks off in Srinagar

MOHIT KANDHARI
■ Srinagar

The International Film Festival of Jammu and Kashmir (IFFJK) got off to a spectacular start with the traditional rendition of Vande Mataram, followed by the National Anthem, Jana Gana Mana, on the decked-up lawns of Sher-e-Kashmir International Convention Centre, located on the scenic banks of Dal Lake in Srinagar on Monday.

Chief Minister Omar Abdullah, along with a galaxy of Bollywood filmmakers, including Ramesh Sippy, Vidhu Vinod Chopra, SriRam Raghvan and Cinematographer Santosh Sivan, lit the traditional lamp before felicitating them.

Union Minister Dr Jitendra Singh, Punjab Governor Gulab Chand Kataria, Lieutenant Governor Ladakh Vinai Kumar Saxena and Dr Farooq Abdullah also attended the glittering ceremony.

The four-day festival has drawn filmmakers, actors, technicians, academics and film lovers from India and abroad to Jammu and

Kashmir to reconnect the Union Territory with Bollywood and the global film industry.

On the occasion, Chief Minister Omar Abdullah urged distinguished international filmmakers and other dignitaries to send out a clear message that Jammu and Kashmir is open, safe, vibrant and ready to welcome film crews.

He said we are not just opening a cinema event; we are opening a new chapter in the long-storied romance between J&K and the silver screen. He said, Kashmir is not just a location; it is a creative sanctuary, a home for global storytellers.

The Chief Minister said the festival is a declaration of J&K's intent to emerge as a vibrant home for filmmakers, storytellers and creative talent from across the world. Omar also referred to a long list of iconic Bollywood films shot in the Valley in his welcome address while inviting the young filmmakers to return to the paradise on earth and look beyond the screen.

Earlier, interacting with



media persons before the formal ceremony, filmmaker Vidhu Vinod Chopra described his participation in the International Film Festival of Jammu and Kashmir (IFFJK) as an emotional homecoming, recalling his childhood and education in Kashmir and urging local youngsters to believe in their talent.

Chopra said the festival could provide a major opportunity for young filmmakers and help bring films and filmmakers from across the world to Kashmir. "It is an opportunity for youngsters. I see this festival as an opportunity. So many films and filmmakers can come

here," he said.

Actor Fatima Sana Shaikh, who played wrestler Geeta Phogat in the Bollywood biopic Dangal, on Monday said cultural festivals are important platforms that bring people together, provide opportunities to youth and promote regional cinema.

Speaking to reporters on the sidelines of the event, Fatma said she is excited to attend the festival after a long time.

On regional cinema, Fatima said cinema can help showcase the culture, poetry and artistry of different regions. "Regional cinema is important. Through

cinema, poetry, culture and artistry can be showcased. These things have existed for centuries. Spoken words, artistry and all of this are part of our heritage," she said.

Fatima also said an international film festival could open doors for international filmmakers and create more opportunities for film shoots in Jammu and Kashmir.

"It will open doors for international filmmakers. Film shootings happened here earlier and they are happening now as well. It depends. With an international festival taking place, they will also understand what can be done here and what the people are like," she said.

Atal Dulloo, Chief Secretary, Jammu and Kashmir, in his welcome address, said the festival received an overwhelming response, with more than 1,100 entries from 40 Countries.

He said the festival aims to reconnect Jammu and Kashmir with the global world of cinema and invite filmmakers to explore the region.

Clean air practical goal, not environmental aspiration, says NGT's Justice Shrivastava

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

National Green Tribunal Chairperson Justice Prakash Shrivastava on Monday said clean air is not merely an environmental aspiration but a practical goal that can be achieved through dedicated efforts, proper planning and effective implementation at the ground level.

He was addressing the fifth 'Swachh Vayu Sarvekshan Awards', organised by the Union Ministry of Environment, Forest and Climate Change at the Paryavaran Bhavan here on the International Day of Clean Air for Blue Skies. "Development and environmental conservation are not at cross purposes but can go together while maintaining the quality of life for the citizens. It is the responsibility of each citizen to ensure that generations to come can live in a clean environment," Justice Shrivastava said.

"Clean air is not merely an environmental aspiration but a practical goal that can be



achieved through dedicated efforts, proper planning and effective implementation at the ground level," he added.

The Swachh Vayu Sarvekshan is an annual assessment of 130 cities covered under the National Clean Air Programme (NCAP), aimed at encouraging healthy competition among cities and promoting measures to improve air quality. Uttar Pradesh's Lucknow topped the Swachh Vayu Sarvekshan Awards among cities with a population of more than 10 lakh, while Madhya Pradesh's Indore and Jabalpur secured the second and third positions, respectively.

The assessment considers

measures taken by cities on road dust, solid waste management, vehicular emissions, industrial pollution, construction and demolition waste management, other emissions (DG sets and commercial establishments), and Information, Education and Communication (IEC) activities. The awards were based on participation and ranking of all 130 cities in three categories – those with a population below 3 lakh, between 3 lakh and 10 lakh, and above 10 lakh.

The process involved self-assessment by cities, approval by the State-level Monitoring Committee, evaluation by the Central Pollution Control Board (CPCB), field verification by independent committees and selection of 10 best-performing cities.

Asserting that clean air was a fundamental need rather than a luxury, the NGT chairperson said the ultimate objective should be to ensure that children can play outdoors without fear of air pollution.

ISRO chief reassures staff over privatisation concerns

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Bengaluru

Days after some Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO) employees raised concerns about privatisation, its chairman V Narayanan on Monday said the space agency remains a Government organisation and dismissed apprehensions. He said the ISRO is working with private companies and startups to expand India's space ecosystem.

His reaction came after nine employee associations at the ISRO wrote to the Chairman on September 4, seeking official clarification on the proposed transfer of its manufacturing and operational functions to private entities.

Speaking to reporters after the inaugural ceremony of the ninth edition of the Bengaluru Space Expo (BSX) here, Narayanan said India's space programme is about 64-65 years old, and that at present



ISRO Chairman V Narayanan with Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACe) Chairman Pawan Goenka during the inaugural session of 9th Bengaluru Space Expo 2026, in Bengaluru, Karnataka, Monday

there are 56 space assets in the sky serving the common man of the country, but the need is huge

numbers. Recalling that since the space sector reforms were rolled out six years ago, he said, "we are

supposed to hand-hold the private sector, startup companies, and grow the space ecosystem."

"In fact, whenever a PSLV or a GSLV is lifting off, almost 80 per cent budget is invested in Indian industries. A total of 450 industries are working for us," he said.

On the concerns raised by the employee associations, Narayanan said, "So, surely, my colleagues, whatever they have, is a genuine concern. It is our responsibility to clarify." He clarified that the ISRO is not privatised and remains a Government organisation.

"We are working — it's a Government investment, and we are working there. But the only thing is, we now (have) so many activities. The space ecosystem in the country has to grow and the space economy has to grow," he said.

Responding to a question about different voices within ISRO raising concerns, Narayanan said, "We are

20,000 employees...we will address the employees." He further added that ISRO has a system and it regularly talks to its employees. When asked about scientists resigning from ISRO, he said the space agency has 20,000 employees with over 8,000 scientists. "In the last five-six years, if you take the statistics, somewhere around 150 people per year have resigned. This is normal in any organisation," he said.

He also clarified that the space agency had no shortage of budget and said whatever ISRO needs, the Government has been allotting it.

Meanwhile, speaking to reporters here, Indian National Space Promotion and Authorisation Centre (IN-SPACE) Chairman Pawan Goenka said that everything that they are doing is consistent with the space policy.

Referring to the space policy, he said that the role of IN-SPACE and

NewSpace India Limited (NSIL) is very clearly defined, and there is not even an iota of digression from what is in the Indian space policy. So all the technology transfer that we are doing is as per Indian space policy.

He reiterated the ISRO chief's assertion that the organisation's projects were progressing fully as planned, with no disruption, slowdown, budgetary constraints or shortage of manpower.

He clarified that it is not ISRO versus industry. Instead, it is ISRO and industry taking on the world. "Right now, we are an about USD 8 billion space economy. We are targeting \$44 billion by 2033. That cannot be done with ISRO alone; it cannot be done with industry alone. It has to be industry and ISRO together. ISRO will be supporting in a very big way, as it has been doing in the last several years, and it will continue to support," Goenka added.

Mizoram electoral rolls see 78,442 deletions



PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Aizawl

Mizoram's electoral rolls underwent a significant change during the SIR exercise, with 78,442 names deleted and 39,243 new electors added, taking the state's final voter count to 8.35 lakh, a senior official said on Monday.

The final roll also recorded the state's first third gender elector, alongside 4 lakh male and 4.32 lakh female voters, according to State Chief Electoral Officer @Garima Gupta.

The SIR was launched across all districts on May 20, alongside 15 states and two Union Territories covered in the third phase of the nationwide revision exercise.

Before the Special Intensive Revision (SIR), the state had 8.75 lakh registered electors, all of whom were provided enumeration forms, Gupta said. Of these, 8,28,906 forms were collected, while 46,162 remained uncollected and the voters' names were subsequently deleted, she said.

"The draft electoral rolls published on July 4 contained 8,28,906 electors.

During the claims and objections period, which ended on 2 September, 32,280 more names were removed while 39,243 voters were added, resulting in a net increase of 6,963 electors or 0.84 per cent from the draft rolls, in the final rolls," Gupta told a news conference.

Congress questions delay in proroguing Monsoon Session

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The Congress on Monday questioned the delay in proroguing Parliament's Monsoon Session, wondering if the home minister is still scrambling for his "super-tainted" two-thirds majority to get the delimitation bills passed. "Today is exactly 25 days since Parliament was adjourned sine die. But it has still NOT been prorogued," Congress general secretary Jairam Ramesh said in a post on X. "Normally prorogation takes place 3-4 days after adjournment sine die. But the gap for the Monsoon Session in 2015 was 28 days. That session had been washed out almost entirely over the Lalit Modi issue, but the Modi Government kept the session alive, hoping to bulldoze the GST bills through.



It needed a two-thirds majority in the Rajya Sabha which it did not have.

"As it turned out, the Modi Government was forced to consult more meaningfully with the Opposition and pass the Bills much later," he said. Ramesh said, "The 2026 Monsoon Session has been kept on ventilator because the Home Minister is still scrambling around for his super-tainted two-thirds majority in the Lok Sabha to get the Delimitation Bills

passed. How much longer before he accepts the reality that his politics of threats and intimidation have reached its limit?" "How much longer before he accepts the reality that his politics of threats and intimidation have reached its limit?" the Congress leader said.

The Lok Sabha and the Rajya Sabha were adjourned sine die on August 13.

During the Budget Session on April 17, the Modi Government faced a setback as the Constitution Amendment Bill, involving delimitation for the implementation of the women's reservation in the Lok Sabha and state assemblies, was defeated in the Lower House. Of the 528 MPs who voted in Lok Sabha, 298 voted in support, while 230 opposed it. The bill required 352 votes for a two-thirds majority.

CPI(M) demands immediate halt to privatisation of ISRO

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ New Delhi

The CPI(M) on Monday demanded an immediate halt to what it termed the "privatisation" of the Indian Space Research Organisation (ISRO), alleging that the move could compromise national security and create dependence on private players in strategically-important areas.

"The Communist Party of India (Marxist) denounces the privatisation of ISRO and demands its immediate halt," the party's Politburo said in a statement.

It said the ISRO's contributions to defence, agriculture, disaster management, weather forecasting and remote sensing are "strategically important for India's economy and security".

"Privatising such a critical, self-reliant institution would create unwanted dependence on the private sector in matters of vital national importance," the party said. The CPI(M) also questioned



recent remarks by IN-SPACE chairman Pawan Goenka that the ISRO would no longer manufacture launch vehicles.

"Pawan Goenka's comments that ISRO will no longer manufacture launch vehicles reveals a sinister design of handing over space research infrastructure built over seven decades by dedicated Indian scientists to private players," it said.

The party claimed that the shift is part of the Indian Space Policy 2023, which opened the space sector to

accountability". The party further criticised the clarification issued by the ISRO in response to concerns raised by the Joint Action Committee of ISRO Staff Associations in its letter to the chief of the space agency.

"ISRO's clarification issued in response to concerns raised by the Joint Action Committee of ISRO Staff Associations through their joint letter to the ISRO chief attempts to defend the policy. However, it fails to address the core anxiety that national security may be compromised," the CPI(M) said.

The party said it stands with the scientists, technologists and staff seeking the strengthening of the ISRO.

"The CPI(M) stands for the protection of the country's strategic interests and with the scientists, technologists and staff who are demanding the strengthening of ISRO. It opposes all the attempts to privatise such a crucial institution," it said.

Karnataka rejects Kasturirangan report on Western Ghats

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Shivamogga

Karnataka Minister Madhu Bangarappa on Monday said the state Government would not allow implementation of the Kasturirangan report under any circumstances and assured people in Malnad that their land, agriculture and livelihoods would be protected.

The Kasturirangan Committee had recommended declaring 37 per cent of the Western Ghats, covering around 60,000 sq km across six states (Gujarat, Maharashtra, Goa, Karnataka, Kerala, and Tamil Nadu), as an Eco-Sensitive Area to balance environmental conservation with development.

"The Kasturirangan report will not be allowed to be implemented under any cir-



Madhu Bangarappa

cumstances. Our Government is committed to protecting every household in Malnad," Bangarappa said while addressing a Congress padayatra and protest in Thirthahalli, demanding that the report be scrapped.

The padayatra, led by former minister Kimmane Ratnakar, began at Binthala and culminated at the Shanthaveri

Gopalagowda Rangamandira. Congress workers raised slogans against the BJP and the union Government during the procession. Bangarappa, who holds the School Education and Literacy portfolio, said the Congress had consistently opposed the Kasturirangan report and recalled that a Cabinet sub-committee was constituted on the issue during Siddaramaiah's tenure as chief minister after he entered the Assembly for the first time in 2013. "Based on the recommendations of the committee, the report was rejected outright. The Congress party has opposed the Kasturirangan report from the beginning," he said. The issue was not merely about opposing a notification but about protecting the land, agriculture, livelihoods and future of Malnad, he said.

"The Western Ghats are our pride and environmental protection is necessary. But in the name of environmental protection, we cannot accept any measure that puts the people of Malnad, who live in harmony with the environment, into difficulty," Bangarappa said.

Farmers across Shivamogga and neighbouring Malnad districts are seeking a physical survey and the exclusion of human settlements and cultivated land from the proposed ESA boundaries.

Turning his criticism on the BJP, Bangarappa questioned its leaders' participation in discussions on the issue, asking whether Shivamogga MP B Y Raghavendra and then Udipi-Chikkamagaluru MP Shobha Karandlaje had attended a crucial meeting convened by

the Centre on August 11, 2016.

"Today, the BJP is making big statements on this issue. But did Raghavendra and Shobha attend that meeting?" he asked. Bangarappa said Karnataka had rejected the Kasturirangan report several times and the Legislative Assembly had passed a resolution against it and sent it to the Centre. "Despite this, the BJP Government at the Centre has been issuing notifications repeatedly. Now, the draft notification has been issued for the seventh time, which has caused anger," he said.

He said 139 villages in Thirthahalli taluk had figured in the first six draft notifications, while the latest draft proposed increasing the number to 154. "What is local BJP MLA Araga Jnanendra doing on this issue?" he asked.

Declare Bihar floods a national disaster: Tejashwi to PM

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Patna

Leader of the opposition in the Bihar Assembly, Tejashwi Yadav, on Monday wrote a letter to Prime Minister Narendra Modi demanding declaration of the state's floods as a "National disaster" and immediate financial assistance of ₹5,000 crore to the State to tackle the situation.

In his letter, Yadav alleged that the "financially bank-



rupt" Bihar Government "persistently failed in taking response, mitigation and adaptation measures" and

was "indifferent" to helping flood victims.

Fed by heavy rainfall, rivers have swelled and inundated 13 districts of Bihar, affecting 27 lakh people, officials said. So far in September, the state received 69.1 mm of rain, which is 55 per cent above normal. Describing flood relief and rescue arrangements made by the NDA Government in the state as "grossly inadequate," Yadav

claimed that the Bihar ministers and the ruling alliance's Union ministers and MPs elected from Bihar appeared "helpless, ineffective and incapable" in the wake of the disaster.

"They have neither been able to get the Centre to declare the severe floods a national disaster nor have they been able to strongly demand a special relief and assistance package for Bihar," he said.

58 lakh records to be displayed, camps for Maratha caste certificates : Patil

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Mumbai

Maharashtra Minister Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil on Monday said 58 lakh records traced by the retired Justice Shinde Committee will be displayed in gram panchayats, and camps will be organised from September 10 to 17 to help Marathas complete documentation for caste certificates.

Vikhe Patil, who heads the state Government's Maratha reservation sub-committee, directed divisional commissioners and district collectors



Radhakrishna Vikhe Patil

to ensure proper coordination and take the issues concerning reservation seriously. The minister was review-

ing the implementation of decisions taken on the Maratha reservation issue during a virtual meeting with collectors and sub-divisional officers from Dharsiv, Beed, Chhatrapati Sambhajinagar, Parbhani, Hingoli, Latur and Jalna districts of Marathwada.

He reviewed district-wise data on caste verification certificates issued, Kunbi records traced and applications received. The collectors also presented details of the action taken and implementation measures undertaken so far. Vikhe Patil said the

Parbhani district collectorate had published the records it had found, and directed other districts to take similar action and publish details on their websites.

He said that 58 lakh records traced by the retired Justice Shinde Committee will be displayed in gram panchayats, and directed the administrations to make proper arrangements for camps from September 10 to 17 to help Marathas complete the requirements for certificates. Speaking to reporters after the meeting, Vikhe Patil said the state Government

would follow the law while issuing certificates.

"No one is above the law. Certificates will be issued only by following genealogical records and legal rules," he said. Around 3.5 lakh Kunbi certificates have been distributed in Marathwada, he said, adding that the rules would be strictly adhered to while issuing certificates to eligible beneficiaries.

He further said that the Government would hold discussions with Maratha quota activist Manoj Jarange, who is on a hunger strike in Jalna. The Government was

taking steps to provide reservation to the Maratha community without affecting the reservation of any other community, he asserted.

"If some people are deliberately using the language of agitation to oppose Maratha reservation, it is wrong and an attempt to unnecessarily create social tension," Vikhe Patil said.

Responding to Jarange's allegation that the Government was only making assurances on Maratha reservation, the minister said that action had been taken on most of the

demands raised during the previous agitation and efforts were underway to find a way forward on the remaining demands.

The Government has always been ready to discuss the reservation issue with Jarange, he said, reiterating that its stand was to provide reservation to the Maratha community without affecting the quota of any other community.

The issue would be resolved within the legal framework and keeping the interests of all communities in mind, Vikhe Patil said.

BJP wins 44, Congress 16 in Rajasthan civic polls



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE ■ Jaipur

Seventy-seven candidates, including 37 women, have been elected unopposed in Rajasthan's urban local body polls, with the ruling BJP accounting for 44 of the victories and the Congress 16, according to election officials.

Among the unopposed winners, 37 are women. The Congress's Sofia (22) from Ramgarh Shekhawati Nagar Palika in Sikar district is the youngest of the winning candidates. She is followed by her party colleague Mona Bano from Basani Nagar Palika in Nagaur district.

Editor's TAKE

ISRO must evolve, not retreat

As private companies take a larger role in rocket manufacturing, concerns are growing that it could weaken the very institution that built India's space programme

Days after a flawless GSLV launch put another Indian Earth-observation satellite into orbit, nine employee associations of the Indian Space Research Organisation did something unprecedented: they wrote jointly to chairman V Narayanan, demanding clarity on whether the government intends to strip ISRO of its core function building and launching rockets — and hand it to private industry instead. The trigger was a remark by IN-SPACe chief Pawan Goenka that ISRO will eventually stop manufacturing launch vehicles altogether. The unions fear exactly what they said aloud: that India's space agency is being reduced to a "residual R&D boutique", stripped of the SSLV, PSLV and LVM3 production lines, the new Kulasekarapattinam spaceport and 120 of its own technologies, all migrating to private hands with no roadmap explained to the workforce that built them.

This anxiety did not appear from nowhere. Through this year, ISRO has watched more than a hundred scientists — many from the UR Rao Satellite Centre and Vikram Sarabhai Space Centre, several tied to Gaganyaan itself — walk out for the salaries and stock options on offer at Skyroot, Agnikul and Pixxel. The Department of Space had to freeze routine resignation approvals for scientists on strategic missions just to slow the bleeding. Two consecutive PSLV setbacks and a delayed Gaganyaan timeline have not helped morale.

None of this should obscure what ISRO has actually built. It reached Mars orbit on its first attempt, for a fraction of what any other spacefaring nation had spent on the feat. It landed near the Moon's unexplored south pole, a first for any country. Its PSLV once carried 104 satellites into orbit in a single flight, a world record at the time. NavIC, weather forecasting, disaster warning, rural communication and defence surveillance all run on ISRO-built and ISRO-operated satellites. Every private Indian rocket firm flying today exists in a market ISRO created, using talent ISRO trained and technology ISRO de-risked first.

That history is precisely the argument for keeping ISRO at the helm, not retiring it. There is a real case for private industry taking over volume manufacturing of proven vehicles like the SSLV - it frees scientists for harder problems and lets India launch more, faster. But manufacturing capacity is not the same as sovereign capability. Deep-space missions, human spaceflight, strategic and defence payloads, and next-generation propulsion must stay under ISRO's direct control - because private firms are not yet built to carry that risk, and because a nation's space programme is a strategic asset, not a supply chain to be handed off.

The government owes these nine associations, and the country, the plan it has so far declined to publish: how ISRO's functions move to industry, on what timeline, and how ISRO's scientists are retained, paid and promoted through the transition. Ambiguity, not privatisation, is what is emptying ISRO's corridors. India can build a space economy that includes private industry without hollowing out the institution that made a space economy possible in the first place.

Sifting the wheat from the chaff

The debate over Jauhar in *Padmaavat* has exposed an uncomfortable tendency in contemporary discourse: judging the past entirely through the moral vocabulary of the present. There is nothing wrong with questioning whether a modern film can inadvertently romanticise a practice that constitutional morality rightly rejects today



BHOPINDER SINGH

There are really two separate questions in the controversy over an actor's comments on the Jauhar sequence in *Padmaavat* — what Jauhar meant in its historical context, and what message a modern film depicting it may convey to a contemporary audience.

The latter is a perfectly legitimate subject for debate. But the former cannot be reconstructed entirely through the moral vocabulary of the present.

The fundamental problem with drawing a direct parallel between Jauhar and rape survivors is that it conflates two profoundly different circumstances. Rape is an act of sexual violence forcibly inflicted upon a woman. Jauhar, in the historical context in which it is remembered, was understood as a collective act undertaken by women facing the imminent prospect of capture, sexual violence, enslavement and dishonour following defeat. That does not require us to endorse Jauhar today. It requires us to understand what the act meant to those who undertook it. And this distinction matters.

To say that Jauhar should not be practised today is uncontroversial. Nor should practices such as sati be romanticised or encouraged. Modern constitutional morality, individual liberty and the sanctity of life rightly reject such practices. But rejecting a historical practice in the present is different from denying the historical and cultural ideas that gave rise to it. In fact, there is a much larger principle here — one that applies to every faith and every civilisation.

The entire edifice of religious and cultural belief rests, in varying degrees, upon scriptures, epics, mythologies, oral traditions, poetry and literature. These bodies of work cannot be read as literal, contemporary instruction manuals. Their stories, symbols, metaphors and moral frameworks have been interpreted across centuries, often differently by different generations.

We do not ordinarily insist that every episode in a religious epic must be reproduced literally in modern life merely because it appears in a sacred or revered text. We understand that there is a distinction between the literal act, the historical or mythical narrative, and the philosophical or spiritual idea that generations have derived from it. That same intellectual generosity ought to extend to history.

The Rajput conception of honour, sacrifice



ONE CAN FIERCELY DEFEND ONE'S HISTORY WITHOUT BECOMING UNCIVIL. ONE CAN REJECT A MODERN INTERPRETATION WITHOUT THREATENING THE PERSON MAKING IT. ONE CAN CONDEMN JAUHAR AS A PRACTICE TODAY WITHOUT PRETENDING THAT THE WOMEN WHO UNDERTOOK IT CAN BE UNDERSTOOD WITHOUT REFERENCE TO THE WORLD IN WHICH THEY LIVED

The writer is a former Lieutenant Governor of the Andaman and Nicobar Islands and Puducherry, and a military veteran

and choosing death over dishonour is part of a historical ethos that communities have developed and internalised over centuries. We may disagree profoundly with particular manifestations of those values today, just as modern society has rejected many practices once considered legitimate. But reducing such traditions entirely to their literal physical acts, and then judging the entire cultural imagination behind them exclusively through a contemporary lens, risks stripping history of the very context required to understand it.

Otherwise, we create an extraordinarily double standard — we grant mythology the benefit of metaphor, symbolism and historical context when it belongs to our own traditions, while demanding literalism from the history and literature of others.

The actor is entirely entitled to ask whether the *Padmaavat* sequence, when viewed today, could inadvertently suggest to a survivor of sexual violence that death is preferable to survival.

That is a legitimate contemporary feminist question. Indeed, she has clarified that her objection was to what she believed the scene could communicate to rape survivors, rather than an assertion that the women who performed Jauhar were cowards. But that contemporary question should not become a substitute for historical understanding.

A society progresses not by erasing the moral frameworks of its past, nor by pretending that yesterday's values must remain today's values, but by understanding why those values existed and then consciously evolving beyond them. This is why the debate is not really about being "woke" or "anti-woke". That framing is itself intellec-

tually lazy. Progress is predicated on learning, questioning and evolving. But learning requires context. If history is selectively excavated merely to stitch together a presumptively progressive contemporary position, we are no longer learning from history; we are weaponising it.

There is another side to this debate that deserves equal emphasis. The anger of the Rajput community at what it perceives as an insensitive or historically reductive characterisation is understandable. But legitimate disagreement loses its moral force when it turns into personal abuse, threats, misogyny, or allusions to a person's marriage, religion or private life. Such conduct does not defend history; it diminishes the very community invoking that history.

If there is one lesson that the Rajput historical imagination ought to carry alongside its celebrated valour and fearlessness, it is also civility, dignity, restraint and large-heartedness. One can fiercely defend one's history without becoming uncivil. One can reject a modern interpretation without threatening the person making it. One can condemn Jauhar as a practice today without pretending that the women who undertook it can be understood without reference to the world in which they lived.

And one can defend the historical meaning of Jauhar without suggesting that a woman who survives rape has somehow lost her honour or her right to live. That, perhaps, is the nuance missing from both extremes of this debate. History deserves context. Faith deserves interpretation. Survivors deserve dignity. Communities deserve respect. And the present deserves the freedom to evolve without falsifying the past.

Daiv Vani

WISDOM FOR A MEANINGFUL LIFE

The Student Who Became the Wall of Water

In the ashram of Sage Dhaumya lived a devoted student named Aruni. One stormy evening, the sage noticed a breach in the mud wall holding back water meant for the fields. If it widened, the crops that fed the entire ashram would be lost.

Dhaumya asked his students to fix it. Most tried briefly, then gave up against the storm, rain and darkness. Aruni did not return. Worried, the guru went searching and found him lying across the gap, using his own body to hold back the rushing water, enduring the rains, cold and the current throughout the night.

When Dhaumya found him, he was moved, not by the wall that now held, but by the depth of Aruni's surrender. No one had been watching, no reward waited, yet he had given everything anyway.

This is what real learning asks of us: not just understanding with the mind, but proving it through sacrifice when no one is measuring, a wholehearted effort when walking away would be far easier.

This week, take one responsibility you've been given, and instead of doing the minimum, protect it as though it were entirely yours. Notice what changes when you stop asking "is this enough," and start asking "have I given everything I have."

—DAIV

India's new music stars go independent

NAMRATA KOHLI

2ND OPINION

For decades, the route to becoming a music star in India usually ran through cinema. Singers became famous through playback, songs travelled on the back of films, and soundtracks dominated popular listening. That model is now being disrupted.

A new report on India's streaming economy suggests that artist-first music — tracks created and released outside film soundtracks — is rapidly moving into the mainstream. According to Spotify's Loud & Clear India report, half of its year-end top 10 in India in 2025 came from outside film soundtracks, while 90 per cent of tracks on its Daily Top 50 were by Indian artists.

Names such as Anuv Jain, Aditya Rikhari, Kushagra and Faheem Abdullah are emblematic of a generation building audiences around the artist rather than the movie.

increased almost seven-fold between February 2023 and February 2026.

It reflects a marketplace where artists no longer necessarily have to migrate towards Hindi to find scale. "When you stay true to your culture and art form, you sound authentic," says Vaidya. Young listeners, he adds, relate to the stories and identities of these artists, allowing musicians to build their own fandoms across languages.

And increasingly, those fans may not even be in India. More than 40 per cent of royalties earned by Indian artists on Spotify in 2025 came from listeners overseas. Of the 15 most-exported Indian tracks on the platform, 11 were independent, artist-first releases. Globally, listeners discovered an Indian artist they had never heard before 12.8 billion times during 2025, up 14 per cent year-on-year.

The numbers point towards a fundamental change in the Indian music business. Digital discovery is weakening some of the old barriers of film, geography and language. A singer-songwriter no longer necessarily needs a Bollywood soundtrack to become nationally known; nor does a Malayalam, Haryanvi or Telugu artist have to abandon a regional identity to find a global listener.

Bollywood remains formidable. But for India's next generation of musicians, it is no longer the only stage that matters.

The writer is an author and podcaster and a Senior Fellow at the Ministry of Culture, Government of India

PICTALK

Women from the Dogra community perform rituals during the 'Bachch Dua' festival in Jammu.

PHOTO: PTI

Don't wait for buildings to collapse

The incidence of a fatal building collapse is not merely a reminder for public authorities to keep a check on building safety audits; it is also a gentle reminder for local communities to recognise the dangers of unplanned construction. The building disaster that resulted in the deaths of six identified students, while some others may still remain unidentified, is nothing less than a tragedy.

Such incidents of building collapses are particularly concerning because similar occurrences may be repeated in different parts of India. Unplanned construction, poor building maintenance and infrastructural mismatches are serious urban menaces, especially during the monsoon season.

More than just a responsibility of public authorities, building safety requires citizens to be aware of the seriousness of the matter. Timely maintenance and repairs, as well as adequate architectural planning, are extremely important to ensure the safety of building residents.

We hope that building safety audits will become part of a civic habit. We should all, at an individual level, conduct safety audits of our buildings to help prevent such mishaps.

KIRTI WADHAWAN | KANPUR

EOS-05 boosts space capabilities

The launch of the EOS-05 satellite is a significant step in India's continuing journey in space technology. Earth-observation satellites provide vital information about changes taking place on the ground and can support better management of land, water, forests and other natural resources. The mission reflects India's growing ability to develop and deploy sophisticated space systems. Satellite data has uses beyond space, helping farmers assess crops, monitor water resources, assess disaster damage and support urban planning, environmental monitoring and infrastructure development.

The achievement highlights the need for sustained investment in research, innovation and indigenous technology. Strengthening cooperation among ISRO, educational institutions and private companies can help India develop more advanced satellites and create a larger ecosystem for space-based applications. Building skilled human resources should remain an equally important priority. The real success of EOS-05 will ultimately depend on how effectively its data is converted into public value. With consistent investment and effective utilisation, India's space programme can contribute meaningfully to economic growth, environmental protection and national preparedness.

RUKMA SHARMA | PUNJAB

India-EU partnership gains momentum

Apropos "Belgium hedges against an unpredictable US" (September 7). The growing India-EU partnership is welcome, but its value will depend on how far it moves beyond diplomatic assurances. Europe's search for greater strategic autonomy offers India an opportunity to build a more balanced economic relationship, particularly in defence, technology and clean energy. Yet trade agreements should not become exercises in political symbolism. Both sides must address market access, regulatory differences and the concerns of smaller businesses before announcing ambitious targets. India should seek practical cooperation in areas where European expertise can strengthen domestic capabilities, including renewable energy, advanced manufacturing and research. Belgium's experience in defence production and its role in European institutions could be useful in this regard. At the same time, India must avoid replacing one form of dependence with another. Diversifying partnerships is sensible, but self-reliance requires investment in skills, innovation and competitive industry.

The trade relationship should prioritise jobs, fair competition and mutual economic benefit. Europe must respect India's development priorities.

A MYILSAMI | COIMBATORE

How are India and Japan reimagining energy security?

As geopolitical tensions and volatile fuel markets reshape energy security, India and Japan are turning to domestic renewable resources. Their initiative to develop 1,000 compressed biogas (CBG) plants in India by 2030 combines India’s abundant biomass with Japan’s technology and financing



AKANKSHA JAIN

When people think about the energy transition, they usually picture solar panels, wind turbines and electric vehicles. However, the recent meeting between the Indian Prime Minister Narendra Modi and the Japanese Premier Sanae Takaichi in New Delhi suggests that both countries are beginning to see energy security differently. Among the several announcements on bilateral energy cooperation, the launch of the India-Japan Cooperative Biogas for Growth Initiative stands out. The initiative aims to support the development of 1,000 compressed biogas (CBG) plants by 2030 in India. In an era marked by geopolitical uncertainty, volatile fuel markets and increasingly fragile supply chains, the question is no longer simply how to generate cleaner electricity. It is also how to produce the fuels that modern economies will continue to need and to do so from domestic resources.

The crisis in West Asia has underscored the strategic importance of energy security. It has also exposed how the concept itself has evolved through three dimensions. For decades, energy security has been centred on securing uninterrupted supplies of oil and gas. The clean energy transition introduced the second one, focused on technologies, critical minerals and manufacturing supply chains, supply chains that remain concentrated in a handful of countries. A third dimension is now emerging that involves securing domestic renewable resources for reducing dependence on both imported fuels and imported clean-energy technologies. While electricity would power much of the future economy, modern economies cannot run on electrons alone. Industries such as steel, fertilisers, chemicals, shipping, aviation and long-haul freight will continue to depend on molecules for decades. Therefore, a more successful and strategic energy transition should seek where electrons are sufficient, where molecules are indispensable, and how those essential molecules can increasingly be produced from domestic renewable resources.

This is where the India-Japan partnership becomes strategically important in addressing their complementary energy security vulnerabilities. With over 90% of its crude oil and nearly all its LNG sourced from overseas, Japan’s energy insecurity remains overwhelmingly molecular and import-dependent. In addition to the risks of geopolitical vulnerabilities, this also contributes to annual greenhouse gas emissions of approximately 994 million tonnes of CO₂-equivalent, the key barrier to Japan’s 2050 net-zero target. Under this partnership, Japanese public and private entities provide finance, advanced technologies and equipment to support CBG projects in India. The resulting emission reductions are quantified, verified and authorised as Internationally Transferred Mitigation Outcomes under Article 6.2 of the Paris Agreement. These mitigation outcomes are allocated between India and Japan according to their agreed financial and technological contributions, with Japan applying its authorised share towards its Nationally Determined Contributions and, where applicable, voluntary corporate climate commitments. For Tokyo, supporting renewable gas projects is also a way to diversify future energy options while advancing its international decarbonisation commitments.

India, meanwhile, faces a dual challenge of energy security and systemic decarbonisation. It imports nearly 90 per cent of its crude oil requirements and around 50 per cent of its natural gas demand, while its rapidly expanding clean energy transition remains heavily dependent on imported solar modules, battery technologies and upstream processing of critical minerals.

In other words, India’s vulnerabilities extend across both molecules and electrons. Since CBG is produced from domestic feedstocks — cattle dung, agricultural residues, municipal organic waste and industrial biomass —CBG simultaneously addresses energy security, waste management and methane emissions while creating value from domestic resources.

Unlike crude oil, LNG or battery minerals, its feedstock cannot be monopolised by distant producers or disrupted by maritime conflict. Also, unlike several emerging energy carriers like hydrogen that still require new supply chains and infrastructure, CBG can leverage existing gas networks. The partnership is also economically complementary. India possesses one of the world’s largest and



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FROM DOMESTIC
RESOURCES

The writer is a Research Associate at the Centre for Climate Change and Energy Transition, Chintan Research Foundation

most diverse biomass resources, generated by its extensive agricultural sector, livestock population and growing urban organic waste streams. Japan, meanwhile, brings technology through precision engineering and project financing.

Rather than competing in the same segment of the value chain, the two countries bring different strengths to building a regional renewable gas economy. More importantly, this cooperation leverages India’s existing GOBARdhan programme and the National Dairy Development Board’s extensive cooperative network, providing an institutional foundation for scaling feedstock collection, avoiding the starting-from-scratch route. But none of this suggests that scaling compressed biogas will be straightforward. India’s principal constraints lie less in technology than in systems integration.

Countries routinely map their coal reserves, oil fields and critical mineral deposits because they are recognised as strategic assets. Biomass resources deserve similar treatment. Crop residues, cattle dung, food waste and organic municipal waste constitute dispersed but significant domestic energy reserves in the form of residual and renewable carbon. This biomass is geographically dispersed, seasonal, variable in quantity and quality, and generated by millions of small producers. Establishing transparent pricing mechanisms, village-level aggregation centres and reliable collection systems, while ensuring that its qualitative characteristics for digestion are maintained, will be as important as constructing digesters themselves. While this complicates logistics, it also makes domestic energy supply inherently more resilient by reducing dependence on single points of failure.

Another, more manageable challenge is the infrastructure. Pipeline connectivity, gas compression facilities and assured offtake remain essential for commercial viability. Without investment in downstream infrastructure, new plants risk becoming underutilised assets. The third challenge is market development. Stable pricing mechanisms, harmonised gas quality standards, stronger carbon market incentives and recognition of digestate as a valuable fertiliser are necessary to improve project economics. India’s experience with renewable energy offers an important lesson. Rapid expansion of solar generation often outpaced transmission infrastructure, leading to curtailment and stranded capacity in some regions. The CBG sector should avoid repeating this mistake by investing as much in logistics and distribution as in plant construction.

One underappreciated aspect of CBG is renewable carbon. While renewable electricity will power much of the future economy, many industries will continue to require carbon-containing fuels and feedstocks. Biomethane addresses this need by providing not only renewable methane but also renewable carbon, making it more than just another low-carbon fuel. Produced from agricultural residues, livestock waste and organic municipal waste, it can be integrated into existing gas infrastructure while reducing methane emissions, producing organic fertiliser and creating rural economic opportunities.

The significance of the India-Japan biogas partnership therefore extends beyond the number of plants it builds. It reflects a broader shift in energy security, from dependence on imported hydrocarbons and vulnerable clean-energy supply chains towards greater reliance on domestically produced renewable fuels. By combining India’s abundant biomass resources with Japan’s technological expertise, this partnership offers a model for strengthening energy security, accelerating decarbonisation and building resilient energy systems across Asia.

Listen to the body before it demands grace



PRATIKSHA VATS

For years, I treated my body like an unpaid intern - working it to the bone, demanding endless overtime, and offering very little gratitude in return. If I felt a migraine creeping in at my desk, I didn’t pause; I swallowed two painkillers, washed them down with an espresso, and kept typing. If my shoulders were hitched up to my ears in stress, I just considered it the tax for being a responsible adult.

I convinced myself I was fine because I was still standing. I was proud of my ability to “push through”. But what I failed to realise — and what took years of burnouts to understand — is that pushing through isn’t strength. It is a slow, silent borrowing against a bank account that will eventually go bankrupt.

We live in a culture that conditions us to treat our physical frame like a high-performance vehicle — always pushing for more mileage, faster turnarounds, and higher output. We measure our worth by our productivity, demanding relentless efficiency from a living being we rarely stop to thank. When the dashboard lights on our health start flashing, our instinct isn’t curiosity or care; it’s annoyance. We view physical exhaustion as an inconvenience and pain as an enemy to be silenced. We cover the check-engine light with tape, swallow another coffee, and keep driving.

What we fail to realise is that the body is not an opponent to overcome or a machine to run into the ground. It is the most loyal companion you will ever have.

Long before a sudden collapse, a hospital bed, or a heavy medical diagnosis forces us to pull over, the trouble has already begun in the quiet spaces of our daily lives. The break doesn’t start in the cells; it starts as an internal atmosphere. It begins with the invisible weight of internal and external pressure, relentless overthinking, perfectionism, and a background noise of harsh, unforgiving self-talk. We carry an endless list of shoulds: I should be doing more, I shouldn’t be tired yet, I can’t let anyone down.

The body is an exceptionally attentive, sensitive audience to this internal dialogue. It doesn’t distinguish between a real external threat and the threat of your own stressful thoughts. Every time you force yourself past your limits out of fear, guilt, or obligation, your nervous system registers the alarm. Day after day, your body absorbs the weight of these thoughts.

The mind can only hold a burden for so long before it hands the weight down to the physical frame. The body holds your unspoken anxiety in a tight, nervous stomach, stores your unaddressed grief in a heavy chest, and carries your relentless rush in tense joints and elevated blood pressure.

When people finally fall ill, they almost always pinpoint the start of their trouble to just a couple of months ago - the moment the fever broke out, the back seized up, or the fatigue became paralysing. But if you sit with them and ask them to look closer, you discover a deeper truth: the body had been knocking for years. It knocked as a lingering tension headache you ignored. It knocked as a persistent gut issue you dismissed as bad food. It knocked as a sudden, unexplained fog over your concentration, a bout of restlessness, or months of tossing and turning in your sleep. But in our rush to achieve, produce, manage the outside world, and survive, we ignore the knock.

The body is fiercely loyal; it rarely fails without warning. It speaks to us first in quiet, gentle whispers. But when its quiet whispers are ignored long enough, it has to speak louder. And when its shouts are continually bypassed, it simply pulls the emergency brake.

When that brake is pulled, a wave of shock, grief, and betrayal usually follows. We feel angry at our bodies for failing us right when we needed them most. The heart-breaking irony is that our bodies never intended to betray us. They knocked because they were trying to survive us. They forced a full stop because it was the only way left to save our lives from our own relentless pace.

It does not have to reach a crisis for us to change this narrative. Healing, longevity, and true emotional peace begin with a simple, radical, and gentle shift in perspective: recognising that your body is not a machine to be driven into the ground, but the most devoted partner you will ever have in this life. It has carried you through every heartbreak, every late night, every deadline, every milestone, and every silent storm you have ever weathered. It has fought for your survival every single second of your life without you ever having to ask.

We must learn to sit down and listen before our bodies are forced to scream.

Listening doesn’t require a grand, complicated retreat. It starts with a simple, intentional act of quiet stillness. Sit for a while without judgement, without rushing to “fix” anything, and without demanding that your body perform for you. Close your eyes for five minutes and ask your physical self a simple question: How are you actually doing? Notice where you are holding your breath. Unclench your jaw. Drop your shoulders away from your ears. Feel the quiet weariness in your bones that you’ve been sweeping under the rug for months. Acknowledge the physical debt you have accumulated. Your body does not just need basic maintenance; it needs reward. It deserves to be pampered, rested, and thanked for its relentless loyalty. A reward doesn’t have to be grand or elaborate. It can be an extra hour of restorative sleep without guilt, a warm bath without a phone nearby, a slow walk in nature where the only goal is to feel the air in your lungs, or a deep, unfiltered breath that fills your chest completely. Sometimes, the greatest reward you can offer is simply telling yourself, “We have done enough for today. You can rest now.”

Stop waiting for a lab test, a diagnosis, or a doctor’s warning to grant yourself permission to rest. Step off the treadmill of constant demands, offer your body the grace, kindness, and gratitude it has earned, and listen to its gentle voice — long before it has to stop you in your tracks. If you don’t pick a day to rest, your body will pick it for you.



The writer is a nutritionist, health writer and wellness coach

What the Jauhar debate reveals about our fear of complex agency



PRIYANKA CHATURVEDI

Recently, there has been a conversation. A controversy. Over a movie scene from almost a decade ago. An apples-to-oranges comparison made in an attempt to sound like a staunch feminist. But the take is so problematic that it does a huge disservice to women. And yes, it is important enough to debunk it, lest it become an ill-informed idea to propagate - about an act of jauhar in the 14th century to a rape survivor in the 21st-century context.

There is a peculiar irony in some contemporary conversations about women’s agency. We say we want women to have the right to choose. And then, when some women in history made that choice — a decision that we find uncomfortable in this day and age — we decide that they could not possibly have been making choices at all, but were coerced into it.

Let us begin with something that should require no qualification whatsoever:

A woman who survives rape has a right not just to live, but to thrive. And not just to live, but to live a life of dignity.

She does not become impure, dishonoured, damaged or less worthy of love, marriage,

motherhood, work or happiness. The shame and criminal act is that of the accused who has committed the crime, and the dishonour is for him to bear — our laws must ensure that.

I can’t imagine I have to literally spell it out because some made it about a rape survivor choosing life over death, by comparing the 21st-century nation-state situation, which is constitutionally governed with recourse available, to a 14th-century princely statehood choice, where women chose jauhar — choosing death over life in the face of impending defeat, captivity and sexual violence.

Firstly, they are not the same choice, if it isn’t already obvious.

But in case it still isn’t obvious to some brainwashed idea which was spoken recently and is being justified repeatedly — in one case, a woman is subjected to violence against her will. In the other, we are talking about women confronted with an extraordinarily brutal circumstance in which they knew capture could mean enslavement, sexual violence and the loss of control over their own lives and bodies. You can find that choice tragic. But to say that the women who chose jauhar were simply victims of patriarchy is not just misplaced but also an insincere argument.

Worse still, equating jauhar to sati, as though they were interchangeable manifestations of one identical practice. They were not. Sati was associated with the death of a widow following her husband’s death on the same funeral pyre as her husband, an abhorrent



Images are for representative purposes only

idea developed within particular social and cultural contexts. Jauhar belonged to the context of war, siege, defeat and anticipated captivity.

One was connected to widowhood — the other to warfare.

Sati was not just abolished but identified as a criminal act against women once India became a republic. And rightly so.

If we flatten every historical practice involving women’s bodies into one convenient category called “patriarchy”, we stop understanding history and start using history as a prop for contemporary arguments.

Talking of contemporary history, not too long ago, in 2014, during the genocide in Iraq’s Sinjar region, many Yazidi women and girls chose to take their own lives rather than submit to systematic rape, torture and forced conversion by ISIS militants.

after an assault she did not choose. A woman who chose jauhar, in the historical circumstances, was choosing death rather than anticipated captivity and violence.

Those are radically different circumstances. One simple fact: a woman’s agency does not disappear simply because we dislike the choice. We cannot say a woman is empowered when she makes the choice we approve of and brainwashed when she makes the choice we don’t.

I would rather ask a much harder question. Why is it that all through history, a woman’s body has been made a battlefield on which victorious armies asserted power?

Why is it that women have had to contemplate death as an alternative to captivity?

Those are profoundly feminist questions. And it isn’t definitely an illiterate argument that we have been subjected to.

The tragedy of jauhar, or in the case of Yazidi women, is not that women chose death. Perhaps the tragedy is that the world in which they lived gave them only that one terrible choice to deal with. The question should not be of the women but the mindset of such invaders who looked at women as acquisitions to do as they pleased with them.

Also, to put sati, jauhar and rape survivors into one basket is to construct a contemporary analogy out of three profoundly different circumstances.

Sati was a practice that needed to end. Which we did.

Similarly, women who chose jauhar should not have their agency erased merely because we, living centuries later, would make a different choice. Rape survivors have an absolute right to live. No woman should ever be told that her life is less valuable because of sexual violence.

There is no contradiction in holding all three positions. In fact, I would argue that this is what a genuinely feminist reading of history demands.

The goal of feminism cannot be to tell women what the correct choice is. It must be to build a world in which women have choices that do not involve choosing between their lives and their dignity.

That is the world we should be fighting for.

Not rewriting the choices of women who lived in another one.

The writer is a former Member of Parliament (Rajya Sabha) and currently heads Women Led Futures at ORF



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Order Order

Justice Mohapatra sworn in as chief justice of Chhattisgarh HC



Justice Krushna Ram Mohapatra, a senior judge of the Orissa High Court, was sworn in as the chief justice of the Chhattisgarh High Court here on Monday.

Chief Minister Vishnu Deo Sai, senior cabinet ministers and state officials attended the ceremony at Lok Bhavan where Governor Ramen Deka administered the oath of office to Justice Mohapatra.

Born on April 18, 1965, Justice Mohapatra holds a BA LLB degree and enrolled as an advocate with the Orissa State Bar Council in February 1988. He spent 26 years practising across diverse legal fields, including civil, criminal, service, and constitutional matters.

He also served as Additional Standing Counsel for the state of Odisha and the Orissa Public Service Commission, and represented institutions, including Central Cooperative Banks Limited (Keonjhar), Neelachal Ispat Nigam Limited, Bank of Baroda, and the National Institute of Open Schooling under the Ministry of Human Resource Development.

Justice Mohapatra was elevated as a judge of the Orissa High Court on April 17, 2015.

His appointment fills the vacancy created by the retirement of former Chief Justice Ramesh Sinha on September 4. Justice Sanjay Kumar Agrawal had briefly served as the Acting Chief Justice of the High Court from September 5. (PTI)

Removal of TMC billboard: SC asks to raise contentions before HC



The Supreme Court on Monday asked the TMC to raise its contentions over the removal of the party's signboard from its office at Camac Street in Kolkata before the high court.

The top court asked the Calcutta High Court to expeditiously decide the petition filed by the All India Trinamool Congress, also known as the TMC, challenging the Kolkata Municipal Corporation's removal of the billboard from the party's office there. A bench comprising Chief Justice Surya Kant and justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana disposed of the plea filed by the TMC. At the outset, Solicitor General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state government, raised a preliminary objection to the appeal. "My learned friend should not be excited," senior advocate Kapil Sibal, appearing for the TMC, said. The law officer took strong objection to Sibal's submission. "You should not have used this expression... it is just for the media, just because it is a political matter..." the solicitor general said. Sibal said that the billboard was removed without any notice, and the board of Haldiram's, functioning on the ground floor, was not touched. The CJ said the matter is still pending before the high court and remedial orders can be passed there.

"Just because the board was removed, it does not mean the matter has become infructuous... if it is found to be wrongly removed, there can be a mandatory order for restoration," the bench said. It said that the high court can be requested to decide expeditiously.

"In our view, the interim order dated August 28, 20206 has not decided pending issues on merits. Since the High Court is seized of the matter, and there are tentative observations made in the order, the parties are granted liberty to raise their respective contentions before the High Court. We request the High Court to determine all issues that arise for consideration expeditiously," the top court said in the order and disposed of the plea. The controversy relates to the removal of an allegedly unauthorised billboard bearing TMC signage from the building at 9, Camac Street in south Kolkata by the Kolkata Municipal Corporation (KMC), with police assistance. (PTI)

SC allows West Bengal govt to file report on questioning of Abhishek's PA in land-grab probe

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday permitted the West Bengal government to file a detailed investigation report in a sealed cover in support of its claim that Sumit Roy, personal secretary of TMC leader Abhishek Banerjee, was not cooperating with the police in the ongoing probe in the Salboni land-grab case.

Earlier on August 31, the top court had asked the state government to produce records pertaining to the interrogation of Roy. It had also extended Roy's protection from arrest until the next hearing.

On Monday, Solicitor

General Tushar Mehta, appearing for the state government, told the bench of Chief Justice of India Surya Kant and Justices J Joymalya Bagchi and J V Mohana that he wanted to file a "detailed investigation" report of Roy.

"On the last date, a query was (made) whether he was confronted with the issue of large cash deposits. There was detailed interrogation and he remained elusive. I have the transcript. It can be posted tomorrow or the day after," the law officer said.

The submissions were made when the counsel for Roy sought a pass-over of the hearing on grounds that senior advocate Gopal Sankaranarayanan was

Justice Mehta's fresh salvo rocks Rajasthan HC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

In a fresh salvo at Rajasthan High Court judge Sanjeev Prakash Sharma, the Supreme Court's Justice Sandeep Mehta has sent a fourth letter to CJI Surya Kant, accusing Sharma of interfering in an internal judicial enquiry, breaching confidentiality and abusing administrative powers.

Justice Mehta had earlier written three letters on August 2, 10 and 17, accusing Sharma, the then acting chief justice of the Rajasthan High Court, of "maladministration", "malpractices", "nepotism" and "favouritism".

Justice Sharma, who went on leave following a protest by a group of advocates outside his courtroom, had termed the allegations against him as baseless.

Chief Justice of India Surya Kant had, on August 26, said that Justice Mehta's allega-



Justice Sanjeev Mehta (left) Rajasthan HC jude Sanjeev Prakash Sharma (right)

tions against Sharma cannot be adjudicated in the public domain and the judge "must be given a fair opportunity" before any conclusion is reached. In his fourth letter dated August 30, Justice Mehta, whose parent high court is also the Rajasthan High Court, claimed he has "further information" and "material" regarding arbitrary, dubious and patently

"high-handed" acts of Justice Sharma.

Justice Mehta has alleged arbitrary rule changes, judicial interference in a land dispute and broader corruption and administrative breakdown at the Rajasthan High Court.

He said a complaint committee of the High Court was constituted to enquire into the allegations against



a judicial officer who was accused of displaying indecent pictures of a fellow lady officer on his mobile phone.

"Two Resolutions of the committee dated May 21, 2026 and July 9, 2026 clearly record that the Acting Chief Justice (Justice Sharma) has made direct intervention in the enquiry proceedings, hampering the indepen-

dence of the committee and that such intervention could vitiate the enquiry as a whole and also breached the confidentiality of such sensitive proceedings," Justice Mehta wrote.

He alleged that the committee, comprising three female judges of the Rajasthan High Court, recorded the said minutes and refused to proceed with the enquiry.

"The Committee also observed that the Acting Chief Justice caused the records of the Committee to be shared with other officers of the registry and judicial officers, thereby breaching the confidentiality of the enquiry instituted against a judicial officer with grave charges," he claimed.

On August 31, the Supreme Court collegium had recommended Justice Sanjay K Agrawal as the Chief Justice of the Rajasthan High Court.

Justice Mehta had levelled sensational allegations

against Justice Sharma in his three letters to the CJI urging him to appoint a permanent chief justice from outside the state.

Justice Mehta was appointed a judge of the Rajasthan High Court in May 2011. He became Chief Justice of the Gauhati High Court in February 2023 and was elevated to the Supreme Court in November the same year.

Justice Sharma was appointed a judge of the Rajasthan High Court in November 2016 and transferred to the Patna High Court in January 2022.

His request for repatriation to Rajasthan on health grounds was not accepted by the Supreme Court Collegium in March 2023.

He was instead transferred to the Punjab and Haryana High Court.

The Collegium subsequently recommended his repatriation to Rajasthan in May 2025.

State's view on appointment of HC judges not binding on Union Govt: Ex-law minister

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Former Union law minister Ashwani Kumar on Monday said the controversy over the appointment of the Chief Justice of Punjab and Haryana High Court should have been avoided as it negatively impacts inter-institutional and Union-State relations. In a statement, he said that while the views of state governments are sought on the proposed appointment of High Court judges, they are not binding on the Union Government or the President of India.



Justice Ashwani Kumar Mishra was sworn in as the chief justice of the Punjab and Haryana HC on Monday, a day after the AAP government in Punjab objected to the Centre notifying his appointment without awaiting its views, alleging the decision bypassed Constitutional norms and set procedures.

asked for their views on the proposed appointments as High Court judges, their views, while entitled to weight, are not binding on Union Government or President."

"Consultations with state govts concerned do not mean concurrence of the state govt," he claimed. "Withholding of views by the concerned state govt in the matter of appointment of High Court judges could also impact the inter-se seniority amongst the judges of High Courts," he also noted.

Will fix date in marital rape petitions after Union Govt's stand on issue: SC

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Supreme Court on Monday said it will await the stand of the central government on a batch of petitions concerning the criminalisation of marital rape before fixing a suitable date for hearing on the issue.

Senior advocate Indira Jaising mentioned a petition related to the prosecution of a husband for marital rape before a three-judge bench headed by Chief Justice Surya Kant, urging that the batch be listed for a date in November.

Jaising, who appeared for the wife, said although the matters are scheduled to come up for hearing on Wednesday, the Centre was yet to file a substantive reply and that the parties were also yet to exchange the petitions. "Union has not filed a reply, except a preliminary objection.. I am asking for a fixed date of hearing in November. We have not exchanged the petitions. We don't know the commonal-



ity or differences," the senior counsel said.

"Matter is listed on Wednesday. Union will appear. We will see what they say and then we will fix a suitable date accordingly," the bench, also comprising Justices Joymalya Bagchi and V Mohana, said.

Senior advocate Karuna Nundy, appearing for another petitioner, said the matter may be fixed on any date to ensure the completion of pleadings.

The court was told that the batch pertains to constitutional validity and interpretation of the provisions concerning marital rape in the criminal law.

Under the exception clause of Section 375 of the Indian Penal Code, now repealed and replaced by the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, sexual intercourse or sexual acts by a man with his wife, the wife not being minor, is not rape.

Even under the new law, exception 2 to section 63 (rape) says that "sexual intercourse or sexual acts by a man with his own wife, the wife not being under eighteen years of age, is not rape".

The top court had on January 16, 2023 sought the Centre's response on a clutch of petitions assailing the IPC provision which pro-

vides protection to a husband against prosecution for forcible sexual intercourse if the wife is an adult.

Later, it also issued notice to the Centre on a similar plea challenging the BNS provision on the issue.

The newly enacted laws - the Bharatiya Nyaya Sanhita, the Bharatiya Nagarik Suraksha Sanhita (BNS) and the Bharatiya Sakshya Adhinyam -- came into effect from July 1, 2024, replacing the IPC, CrPC and the Evidence Act.

One of pleas is related to the Delhi High Court's split verdict of May 11, 2022 on the issue. The appeal has been filed by a woman, who was one of the petitioners before the Delhi High Court.

While delivering a split judgement, high court judges Justice Rajiv Shakdher and Justice C Hari Shankar had concurred on granting the petitioners a certificate of leave to appeal in the Supreme Court as the matter involved substantial questions of law which required a decision by the top court.

Delhi HC rejects Hindutva influencer's plea against arrest



Security personnel deployed outside the Patiala House Courts ahead of the hearing of social media influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj in an alleged assault case, in New Delhi

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

The Delhi High Court on Monday dismissed a plea by Hindutva influencer Swatantra Bhardwaj against his arrest in connection with the alleged assault on the father of a student activist during a protest at Jantar Mantar. A bench of Justices Navin Chawla and Ravinder Dudeja said Bhardwaj was remanded to custody pursuant to trial court's judicial orders and he can challenge his arrest before the court concerned.

The counsel for Bhardwaj contended that even a single day's custody is illegal, saying the FIR does not exist in the eyes of law. He argued that this was one of the FIRs related to the Cockroach Janta Party (CJP) protest that were quashed by the Supreme Court.

However, the counsel for Delhi Police said Bhardwaj was produced through video conferencing before a sessions judge on Saturday and was sent to one-day police custody. On Sunday, he was virtually produced before a duty magistrate and was remanded to one-day judicial custody. On Monday, he was again produced before a special judge virtually and has been sent to 14 days in judicial custody.

"He is in custody in pursuance to judicial orders, so where is the question of habeas corpus or illegal custody. Once there is a legal

order, they can challenge it before the court concerned," the police counsel contended.

On instructions from SHO of Parliament Street police station, the counsel said this FIR has not been quashed by the Supreme Court.

The counsel for the complaint apprised the court that provisions under the SC/ST Act have also been invoked against Bhardwaj in the FIR.

The court noted that while Bhardwaj's counsel argued that the FIR has been quashed by the Supreme Court, this ground was not raised in the petition. "You have not raised this ground in the petition. Even if we issue notice on the petition, what reply the State would have filed," the bench said, adding that "we fail to understand how this prayer is sought in the habeas corpus petition". The plea filed on behalf of Bhardwaj's father Randhir Kumar Jha was mentioned before a bench of Chief Justice Devendra Kumar Upadhyaya and Justice Tejas Karia for urgent hearing in the morning. Bhardwaj was detained in Bulandshahr on September 4, hours after the CJP staged a protest outside the Parliament Street police station here demanding his arrest over the alleged assault. Delhi Police has added provisions of the SC/ST (Prevention of Atrocities) Act and criminal intimidation to the FIR against Bhardwaj over the alleged assault on Sanjay Kumar, the father of a teenage student activist, during CJP-led protest at Jantar Mantar in June.

PIOTECH

PGIMER marks 63 years with vision for AI-driven healthcare

Artificial Intelligence will fundamentally transform healthcare by augmenting the capabilities of doctors, enabling greater knowledge, efficiency and reach, Prof Ajit Kumar Chaturvedi, Vice-Chancellor, Banaras Hindu University, Varanasi said on Monday.

Addressing the 63rd Institute Foundation Day celebrations of PGIMER, Chandigarh as chief guest, Chaturvedi described Post Graduate Institute of Medical Education and Research as a “true national asset” and lauded its pioneering contributions to healthcare, education, research and innovation.

Delivering the Foundation Day address on “AI in Healthcare”, Prof Chaturvedi described PGIMER as a “true national asset” and lauded its pioneering contributions to healthcare, education, research and innovation.

“PGIMER Chandigarh is, without doubt, a true national asset” not limited to one region, but making a significant contribution to healthcare, education, research and innovation across the country. I congratulate each and every member of the PGIMER family for this remarkable journey and for keeping the institution at the forefront of Indian healthcare,” he said.

Emphasising that AI should be viewed as an enabler rather than a replacement for medical professionals, Chaturvedi said, “The most successful healthcare deployments today are not examples of AI replacing doctors. They are examples of AI helping doctors perform at their best.”

Vice Chancellor of the BHU noted that AI had moved beyond being a technological novelty and was making deep inroads into healthcare, research and decision-making.

“AI is no more something like a fashionable toy or something that is a status symbol. It has made very deep inroads in the market, and naturally, we cannot be just watching it from a distance,” he observed.

Highlighting its potential to process vast volumes of medical information, he said AI could assist doctors in extracting information from clinical records, pathology reports and scientific literature.

(PTI)



When AI takes over the daily UPI payments

India’s UPI revolution may take another leap as AI agents handle small payments for us



RAJESH SETH

For millions of Indians, paying for something has become almost an unconscious act. Buying vegetables from the neighbourhood vendor, we scan the QR code. Paying the kirana store, we scan the QR code. Taking an auto or an Uber, we pay through UPI. Visiting the chemist, restaurant or even the doctor, we reach for our phone rather than our wallet.

In less than a decade, UPI has transformed the way India pays. According to NPCI data, UPI processed a record 24.51 billion transactions worth ₹29.82 trillion in August 2026, nearly 800 million transactions every day or 9150 transactions every second.

India has not merely embraced digital payments; it has emerged as a global pioneer in instant retail payments. UPI has made paying small amounts of ₹50, ₹200 or ₹500 effortless. It is now very difficult to find smaller denomination currency notes in the market or even with bank tellers.

And now something even more significant is on the horizon.

Payments by AI Agents

A Reuters report last week said India is preparing a framework that could allow AI agents to make small UPI payments without requiring users to approve individual transactions. The initial focus is expected to be on low-value, routine purchases, with users setting rules and spending limits in advance.

This may sound like a small technological refinement. It isn’t.

UPI changed the way Indians make payments. Agentic AI could change the way Indians decide to make them.

Today, if you want to buy groceries, you



open Google Pay, PhonePe or another UPI app on your mobile phone, scan the merchant’s QR code and approve the payment. Tomorrow, you might simply tell your AI agent: “Keep my weekly grocery spending below ₹2,000 and ensure the usual household items are replenished.”

The AI could potentially identify what is needed, compare available options, place the order and make the UPI payments, all within the conditions you specified.

The same principle could apply to dozens of mundane transactions with commands like “Pay my electricity bill when it becomes due” or “Book my Uber to the airport if the fare is below ₹600”.

How much discretion can we give AI Agents

For the consumer, the important change is not that the payment becomes faster. Rather, that the consumer no longer needs to initiate every transaction.

This could be particularly useful for small, repetitive and predictable payments.

Instead of remembering bills, monitoring prices or repeatedly approving routine purchases, we could delegate these tasks to an AI agent. Elderly consumers, busy professionals and small business owners could benefit from having routine purchases handled automatically. This also changes the role of the consumer from authorising each transaction to setting the rules under which an AI agent (or a machine) can transact for us securely.

There is, however, a new question: how much financial discretion are we prepared to give the machine?

Suppose the AI orders a product that is cheaper but not the one we normally buy. Suppose it interprets “usual groceries” differently from us. Suppose an online platform manages to influence the agent into



India is particularly well placed for this next stage because the digital payment infrastructure is already in place. UPI has accustomed hundreds of millions of Indians to trusting a QR code with their money. The next step is

considerably more ambitious: trusting an algorithm to decide when and how that money should be spent.

That is the real significance of agentic payments.

The future of digital payments may not be about making it easier for us to tap “Pay”. It may be about making it possible for us to say, “You take care of it.”

The challenge will be ensuring that when the machine acts on our behalf, it never forgets whose money, and whose trust, it has been given.

The author is an alumnus of IIM Ahmedabad and Professor of Practice at IIM University, Gurugram with an interest in AI, technology and strategy

The century of the checker & will it matter for India’s story?

A machine has finished the most famous proof in mathematics in eleven days. The next decade belongs to whoever can tell the truth from output



NISHANT SAHDEV

Sometime around 1637, a French lawyer named Pierre de Fermat was reading a Greek textbook and had a thought. He noted it in the margin.

The claim was simple enough for a schoolchild. You can easily find whole numbers where $3^2 + 4^2 = 5^2$. Try the same with cubes, or fourth powers, or anything above the square, and you will never find any. Then Fermat added the most famous sentence in the history of mathematics. He had discovered a marvellous proof, he wrote, but this margin was too narrow to contain it.

He was almost certainly wrong about having the proof. He was spectacularly right about the margin.

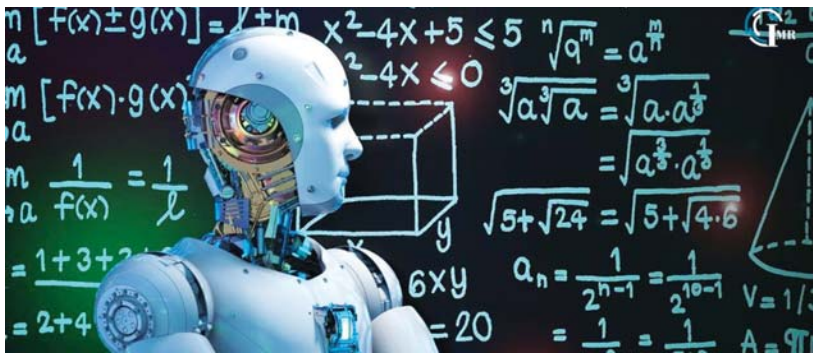
It took 358 years. Andrew Wiles finally settled it in 1995, and even then the first version had a hole in it that took another year and a collaborator to patch. What he produced was a document of well over a hundred pages, written in the compressed dialect of modern number theory, which perhaps a few hundred people on earth could genuinely evaluate. That is how mathematics has always worked. A proof is a piece of writing. It becomes true-for-the-community when enough qualified humans have read it and nodded. Last month, it has a change.

Eleven days

In the early hours of 7 August, a small team at the American AI lab Anthropic pointed several dozen copies of a language model at Wiles’s proof and asked it to write the whole thing out in a language called Lean. Eleven days later, working largely without human direction, the machines were done.

To understand what “writing it out” means, think about giving someone directions. A human mathematician writes directions the way a local gives them: take the second left after the temple, you can’t miss it. Everyone who knows the neighbourhood follows perfectly. Lean is not a local. Lean is a machine that has never been to your city and refuses to take a single step you have not specified. Every “it follows that”, every “clearly”, every move a specialist would unpack silently in their head has to be written down and justified.

That is why a proof of a hundred-odd pages came out the other end at 13 million lines of code. Along the way the system proved 30,300 supporting statements, of which about 29,500 ended up in the final chain, and produced roughly six billion words of output. The finished object is more than five times the size of Mathlib, the shared library that the world’s Lean community has been



assembling for over a decade. Lean then checked the entire structure and accepted it, relying on nothing beyond its three basic assumptions. A separate check confirmed that the thing proved was the real Fermat statement and not a convincing lookalike.

Kevin Buzzard, the Imperial College mathematician who in 2024 launched a five-year funded project to do exactly this job with human volunteers, called it extraordinary. He is not a man given to hype about machines.

Nobody is going to read it

Here is the part that should make you sit up. That 13-million-line file will never be read by a human being. Not skimmed, not spot-checked, not taught. It is not written for us. Its only reader is a program.

We have therefore arrived somewhere genuinely new: a mathematical certainty that no mind comprehends. For four hundred years, “we know this is true” and “somebody understands why” were the same sentence. They have just come apart.

The instinct is to find this frightening. I think the more useful reaction is to ask where the trust went, because it did not disappear. It moved, and it got smaller.

Everything in that gigantic file rests on one small program at the centre of Lean called the kernel, a few thousand lines of code whose only job is to check that each step really follows. We have effectively swapped a jury of a hundred distracted experts for a single very careful judge. That is mostly an upgrade. It is also a concentration of risk, and concentrated risk fails in a particular way. Last summer, a soundness bug in that kernel briefly allowed a bogus “disproof” of a famous unsolved problem to sail through verification before anyone noticed. It was found and fixed. But it is worth saying plainly: machine-checked does not mean beyond doubt. It means the doubt has been squeezed into a smaller, more inspectable place.

A physicist’s confession

I should admit that in my own field this stopped being news around 1985.

Nobody reads a climate model line by line. Nobody reads the code behind a lattice simulation of the strong nuclear force, or the pipeline that turned raw detector counts into the Higgs boson. These are millions of lines written by hundreds of people across decades, and no single human has ever held one in their head. Physics learned to live with it. We trust results by re-deriving them independently, by running rival implementations, by demanding that two groups who dislike each other get the same number, and by publishing an error bar on everything.

Mathematics was the last discipline where one person could, in principle, verify the whole chain personally. That was always its special dignity. It has now joined the rest of us, and it will need to import our habits: independent reimplementations, adversarial checking, and a culture that treats verified-but-unexplained as a real but partial kind of knowledge.

What the machine did not do

It did not discover anything. This matters, and the coverage has mostly missed it.

The system followed Wiles’s route. Its dependency graph closely tracks the original argument. It walked on a road that had been surveyed for it by an 86-page technical blueprint written by human mathematicians, over a decade of accumulated Mathlib groundwork, and a coordination tool built by a research group at Columbia. Its first attempt failed outright. Early runs collapsed because the parallel agents lost track of what had already been proved and kept redoing each other’s work.

So the honest sentence is not “AI proved Fermat’s Last Theorem in eleven days.” It is: the walking became astonishingly fast, and the map is still ours. Eleven days of machine time sits on top of twenty years of human scaffolding that nobody is going to write a headline about.

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

The author is a physicist at the University of North Carolina at Chapel Hill and a contributor at Wall Street Journal

Add to cart, courtesy AI



ROHIT YADAV

For nearly a century, the Indian shopper was won through noise. The biggest hoarding on Linking Road, the catchiest radio jingle, the celebrity endorsement during a cricket match, or the sponsored listing at the top of a shopping app all influenced what eventually landed in our shopping carts. Advertising was never just a business function. It shaped what we noticed, what we trusted and, ultimately, what we bought. That familiar world is now beginning to change, and artificial intelligence is quietly leading the shift.

The clearest glimpse of this future came recently from Glance, an Indian AI platform that has made shopping undergo transformation since the rise of e-commerce. Unlike an online marketplace, Glance does not sell products. Instead, it learns what a user likes, understands their preferences, studies their previous purchases and recommends products that best fit their needs.

Just as online shopping replaced many visits to physical stores, AI assistants may now replace much of the searching, comparing and decision-making that consumers currently do themselves. Instead of opening multiple tabs, comparing prices and reading endless reviews, shoppers could simply ask an AI assistant to find the best option. The AI discovers products, compares alternatives and identifies the best value. These are precisely the functions that advertising has traditionally influenced. As AI performs them itself, the importance of advertising in shaping purchase decisions naturally begins to decline.

The consequences for brands are profound. Companies have always spent heavily to remain in consumers’ minds because familiarity often translates into sales. But an AI assistant does not remember brands the way people do. It has no emotional attachment to a familiar logo or a celebrity endorsement. It can compare thousands of products within seconds and recommend whichever best matches the customer’s needs. That means a relatively unknown Indian manufacturer could suddenly compete with a global brand if its product offers genuinely better quality or value. In this new environment, success will depend less on creating memorable campaigns and more on building products that deserve to be recommended.

This is not a distant trend unfolding somewhere in Silicon Valley. If anything, India appears unusually well prepared for it. A widely cited Capgemini study found that 41 per cent of Indian consumers already use AI-driven shopping tools, while another 40 per cent plan to start soon. That means more



than eight out of every ten Indian shoppers are either already using AI or are ready to let AI influence their buying decisions. No other country in the survey reported a higher figure. In this story, India is not simply adopting a global trend. It is helping shape it.

That advantage is not limited to consumer behaviour. India also has an institutional head start. Long before agentic shopping became a global conversation, the country had already built the Open Network for Digital Commerce (ONDC), a Government-backed protocol designed to do for online retail what UPI did for digital payments. Instead of forcing sellers to compete for visibility within a handful of dominant platforms through expensive

advertising, ONDC allows any buyer application to discover any seller connected to the network.

By 2026, ONDC had expanded to several hundred thousand sellers, more than a hundred buyer applications and operations across hundreds of towns and cities. A kirana shop in a tier-three town can now be discovered by a customer sitting in Pune without paying hefty advertising fees simply to become visible. India reached this point through digital public infrastructure long before AI shopping became mainstream. As agentic shopping grows, that early investment could become one of India’s biggest competitive advantages.

For India’s millions of small and medium enterprises, this convergence between AI and ONDC could be transformative. Many have spent years arguing that rising digital advertising costs make it difficult to compete with larger companies. If AI recommends products chiefly on the basis of quality, value and customer satisfaction, smaller businesses could finally compete on more equal terms. A well-made kurta from a local manufacturer or a competitively priced insurance policy from a lesser-known company could stand alongside products from much larger brands without first having to win an expensive advertising battle.

Advertising, though, is not disappearing, and it would be misleading to suggest otherwise. Every interaction with an AI system requires substantial computing power, known as inference cost, and someone ultimately has to pay for it. Advertising has long funded free digital services, and AI will be no exception. The real change lies in what advertising looks like. Instead of focusing only on attracting human attention, brands will increasingly have to ensure that AI systems understand their products accurately through reliable information about quality, pricing, delivery performance and customer satisfaction. Some technology experts have begun describing this as agent-to-agent optimisation, where a brand’s AI effectively communicates with the consumer’s AI assistant. In that world, structured and trustworthy product information becomes just as valuable as a memorable tagline once was.

The implications extend beyond individual brands. If AI assistants can discover, compare and recommend products independently, even online marketplaces could lose some of the influence they currently enjoy. Much of their power today comes from helping consumers search through millions of products. When an intelligent assistant can perform that task instantly on behalf of the shopper, the marketplace becomes less central to the buying journey. That represents a meaningful shift for India’s digital commerce ecosystem, where a handful of platforms have long shaped product discovery and the advertising economy built around it.

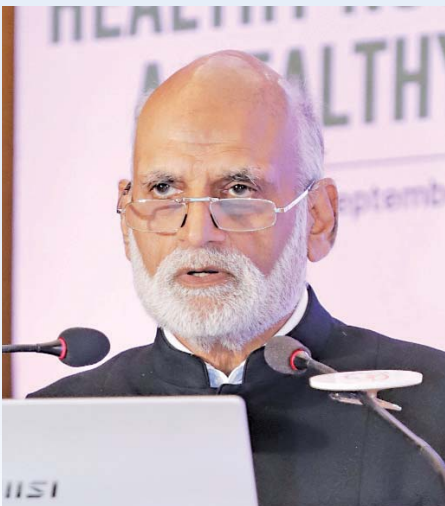
There is, all the same, one reason to remain cautious. The companies building AI shopping assistants are businesses too, and businesses need revenue. Today’s neutral recommendation engine could become tomorrow’s sponsored recommendation if commercial incentives begin influencing what AI suggests to consumers. The technology promises a more level playing field, but that promise will only hold if transparency and fairness remain central to how these systems operate.

Please read the complete article online at dailypioneer.com

The writer is Assistant Professor, IIM Bodh Gaya

BUILDING A HEALTHIER INDIA: THE POWER OF NUTRITION

‘ILLNESS TO WELLNESS’ CONFERENCE HIGHLIGHTS NEED FOR NUTRITION AWARENESS, FOOD SAFETY AND COMMUNITY-LEVEL ACTION FOR A HEALTHIER NATION



Mr. Anil Rajput,
Chairperson, Advisory Council,
Illness to Wellness Foundation



Mr. Rajesh Bhushan,
Former Secretary, Ministry of Health &
Family Welfare, Govt. of India &
Chairperson, Governing Council, Illness
to Wellness Foundation



Shri Rajit Punhani,
Chief Executive Officer,
Food Safety and Standards
Authority of India



Prof. Nirmal Kumar Ganguly,
Former Director General, ICMR &
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to Wellness Foundation



**Dr. Neelam Mohan, HOD - Department
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Medanta Hospital**

India's growing emphasis on preventive health-care is placing nutrition and food safety at the heart of efforts to help citizens stay healthy and reduce the long-term burden of disease, said Shri Rajit Punhani, Chief Executive Officer, Food Safety and Standards Authority of India (FSSAI), while addressing the 'Illness to Wellness' Conference on Healthy Nutrition for a Healthy Nation.

Speaking on FSSAI's role in this transition, Shri Punhani highlighted the Authority's efforts to combine food-safety regulation with consumer education and behavioural nudges. He cited initiatives including Eat Right School, Eat Right Campus and Eat Right Thali, along with consumer awareness campaigns, as part of efforts to encourage informed food choices.

Shri Rajit Punhani said, "There is a clear shift in the public-health landscape towards prevention, and food sits right at the centre of this transition. While ensuring that food is safe, wholesome and compliant remains FSSAI's fundamental responsibility, empowering consumers with the right information to make informed choices is equally important. Through initiatives such as Eat Right School, Eat Right Campus, Eat Right Thali and consumer awareness campaigns, we are using education, information and behavioural nudges to make nutrition awareness part of everyday life. This requires collective action, with government, healthcare, academia, civil society, industry and consumers working together to make informed food choices more accessible, affordable and convenient."

The 'Illness to Wellness' Conference on Healthy Nutrition for a Healthy Nation, organised by the Illness to Wellness Foundation, brought together policymakers, healthcare professionals, nutrition experts, educators and representatives from industry and civil society to deliberate on strengthening nutrition awareness, food safety and community-level action.

Mr. Anil Rajput, Chairperson, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, said, "The foundations of a healthy nation are laid much before illness takes a person to the hospital, and nutrition must be at the heart of this transition from illness to wellness. India's nutrition landscape requires us to look beyond food availability towards nutritional security, ensuring access to food that is safe, affordable, diverse and appropriate to individual needs. It is not out of place to mention that the salt, sugar and fat requirements differ across people, regions and activities. Their needs differ and we must remain mindful of that, while creating awareness in the larger section of society. The way forward lies in promoting awareness based on science, balance, moderation and informed choices. Building a healthier India is a shared responsibility, requiring the collective efforts of government, healthcare professionals, schools, responsible industry, civil society, media and communities."

Delivering the keynote address, Mr. Rajesh Bhushan, Former Secretary, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India and Chairperson, Governing Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation, said, "Nutrition cannot be addressed through isolated interventions;



(L to R): Dr. Smriti Pahwa – Director, Scale up, Arogya World; Dr. Manjari Chandra, Senior Consultant, Nutritional Medicine, Max Healthcare; Dr. Jitender Nagpal, Senior Consultant, Paediatric, Sitaram Bhartia Institute of Science and Research; Dr. Zoya Ali Rizvi, Deputy Commissioner, National Health Mission, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Govt of India; Dr. Pulkit Mathur, Joint Secretary, Nutrition Society of India and Professor, Dept of Food & Nutrition and Food Technology, Lady Irwin College, New Delhi and Dr. Satish Koul, Principal Director & Unit Head – Internal Medicine, Fortis Medical Research Institute (FMRI), Gurgaon



(L to R): Dr. Latika Bhalla, Senior Consultant, Adolescent Paediatrics, Sir Ganga Ram Hospital; Dr. Kumud Khanna, Former Director, Institute of Home Economics, University of Delhi and Former National Vice-President, Nutrition Society of India; Dr. Jose Stephen, Principal, Rosary Senior Secondary School, Kingsway Camp, Delhi; Dr. Charu Dua, Chief Clinical Nutritionist, Amrita Hospital, Faridabad; Ms. Anjali Malik, Principal, Jaypee Public School, Noida and Mrs Alka Singh, Principal, Air Force Golden Jubilee Institute, Subroto Park, New Delhi



(L to R): Ms. Kalpana Gupta, Clinical Nutritionist - Nutrition and Dietetics, Max Smart Super Speciality Hospital, Saket; Dr. Sanjay Kumar Mattoo, Joint Commissioner & Addl. Deputy Director General, Central TB Division, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India; Dr. Preeti Khanna, National Program Manager- Health and Nutrition, Project Concern International (PCI) India; Dr. Sukriti Gupta, Senior Consultant, Haematology Oncology & Bone Marrow Transplant Unit, Artemis Hospital; Ms. Ishi Khosla, Member, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation and Chief Nutritionist, Founder, Celiac Society of India and Dr. Rajesh Kesari, Member, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation

it requires a life-cycle approach beginning with pregnancy and continuing through the first 1,000 days, early childhood, school years and adulthood. The challenge is not only to create awareness but to translate that awareness into healthy behaviour, particularly in rural and underserved communities. Our frontline health workers, Anganwadi systems and schools provide an important institutional network through which nutrition interventions can reach families at scale. We already have programmes and guidelines in place; the priority now must be effective implementation, continuous monitoring and the use of practical behavioural approaches that help people make healthier choices."

The inaugural session highlighted the importance of strengthening nutrition outcomes across different stages of life, with discussions covering maternal, child and adolescent nutrition, anaemia and malnutrition, food safety and

nutrition standards, safe and nutritious food choices, and the role of different stakeholders in taking national nutrition priorities to the grassroots.

Further, taking the discussion ahead, Dr Zoya Ali Rizvi, Deputy Commissioner, National Health Mission, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India, said, "The real impact of nutrition programmes will come from taking information to the grassroots and listening to the needs of communities. Our 10.5 lakh ASHAs and Anganwadi workers are the backbone of this effort, and strengthening communication through their insights can help translate awareness into meaningful action."

Dr. Sanjay Kumar Mattoo, Joint Commissioner & Additional Deputy Director General, Central TB Division, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India, said, "Malnutrition remains one of the biggest health challenges facing our society and has a close bearing on

the fight against tuberculosis. Addressing this challenge requires a collective effort from all stakeholders, including the government, health-care system, media, parents, schools and communities, to strengthen awareness and support effective action against malnutrition and TB."

The conference also featured three focused sessions that explored the role of nutrition across different stages of life and its linkages with disease prevention and public health.

The first session, "Poshan Jan Andolan: Awareness to Action for Healthier Women, Children and Families," focused on translating nutrition awareness into sustained action, with discussions around breastfeeding and complementary feeding, anaemia and micronutrient deficiencies, balanced and affordable diets, and the role of technology, media and communities in driving behaviour change.

The session was moderated by Dr. Jitender

Nagpal, Senior Consultant, Paediatrics, Sitaram Bhartia Institute of Science and Research, Delhi, and featured insightful perspectives from a distinguished panel comprising Dr. Zoya Ali Rizvi, Deputy Commissioner, National Health Mission, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India; Dr. Manjari Chandra, Founder, Manjari Wellness and Senior Consultant, Nutritional Medicine, Max Healthcare and Everhope Oncology; Dr. Pulkit Mathur, Joint Secretary, Nutrition Society of India and Professor, Department of Food & Nutrition and Food Technology, Lady Irwin College, New Delhi; Dr. Smriti Pahwa, Director - Scale Up, Arogya World; and Dr. Satish Koul, Principal Director & Unit Head - Internal Medicine, Fortis Medical Research Institute (FMRI), Gurugram.

The second session, "Healthy Schools, Healthy Children: Safe Food, Better Nutrition, Brighter Futures," examined the need for safe and nutritious food environments for children and ways to strengthen the implementation of food and nutrition guidelines at the school level. The discussion covered healthy school canteens, food safety and hygiene, safe food-handling practices, making nutritious choices accessible and appealing to children, and the role of parents in reinforcing healthy eating habits at home.

The session was moderated by Dr. Latika Bhalla, Senior Consultant, Adolescent Paediatrics, Sir Ganga Ram Hospital, and brought together participation from Dr. Kumud Khanna, Former Director, Institute of Home Economics, University of Delhi and Former National Vice-President, Nutrition Society of India; Dr. Charu Dua, Chief Clinical Nutritionist, Amrita Hospital, Faridabad; Mrs. Alka Singh, Principal, Air Force Golden Jubilee Institute, New Delhi; Ms. Anjali Malik, Principal, Jaypee Public School, Noida; and Dr. Jose Stephen, Principal, Rosary Senior Secondary School, Kingsway Camp, Delhi.

The third session, "Nourishing Health, Ending Disease: Strengthening Nutrition for a TB- and Anaemia-Mukt Bharat," focused on the relationship between malnutrition, anaemia and tuberculosis, including early identification and management of anaemia and nutritional deficiencies, nutrition support for TB patients, and improving access to iron, folic acid, protein and micronutrient-rich foods.

The session was moderated by Dr. Preeti Khanna, National Program Manager - Health and Nutrition, Project Concern International (PCI) India, and discussion brought together insights from Dr. Sanjay Kumar Mattoo, Joint Commissioner & Additional Deputy Director General, Central TB Division, Ministry of Health & Family Welfare, Government of India; Dr. Sukriti Gupta, Senior Consultant, Haematology Oncology & Bone Marrow Transplant Unit, Artemis Hospital; Ms. Ishi Khosla, Member, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation and Chief Nutritionist and Founder, Celiac Society of India; Ms. Kalpana Gupta, Clinical Nutritionist - Nutrition and Dietetics, Max Smart Super Speciality Hospital, Saket; and Dr. Rajesh Kesari, Member, Advisory Council, Illness to Wellness Foundation and Member, National Executive Committee, RSSDI.

The conference concluded with a call for continued collaboration among government, healthcare professionals, schools, communities, civil society, responsible industry and other stakeholders.



Innovation can take ayurveda to new heights, says Jadhav

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Union Minister of State (I/C) for Ayush and Union Minister of State for Health & Family Welfare, Prataprao Jadhav, addressed the curtain-raiser press conference for the 11th Ayurveda Day 2026 at the National Media Centre, New Delhi. The event marked the commencement of the nationwide campaign leading up to Ayurveda Day. The main Ayurveda Day celebrations will be held on 23 September 2026 in Nagpur, Maharashtra, with "Ayurveda for a Healthier Tomorrow" as its theme, reflecting the vision of connecting India's rich Ayurvedic heritage with the evolving healthcare needs of the future.

In his address, Union Minister Prataprao Jadhav highlighted that the world is increasingly looking towards preventive healthcare, healthy lifestyles, nutrition, wellness and holistic health, areas where India has a rich tradition and experience. He emphasised that Ayurveda Day is not merely



an occasion to celebrate India's heritage, but an opportunity to connect this heritage with the health requirements of the future. In line with the vision of Viksit Bharat under the leadership of Prime Minister Narendra Modi, Prataprao Jadhav highlighted the need for a healthcare approach where health goes beyond treatment of disease and encompasses healthy habits, appropriate diet and daily routines, mental balance and harmony with nature. Jadhav emphasised the important role of the media

in disseminating accurate, evidence-based and simple information on Ayurveda to the public. He called upon the media to support the campaign and take the message of Ayurveda to homes, schools and colleges, young people including Gen Z, and rural and urban communities. Professor Sanjeev Sharma, Vice-Chancellor, National Institute of Ayurveda (NIA), Jaipur, highlighted the key features of Ayurveda Day 2026, which will focus on evidence-based Ayurveda, research and innovation,

integrated healthcare, and community wellbeing and sustainable living. He also outlined the major programmes planned for the occasion, including the National Dhanwantari Ayurveda Awards 2026, along with key initiatives such as new programmes at NIA Jaipur, safety dossiers on medicinal plants, Standard Treatment Guidelines for skin diseases, a report on the Ayush Services Sector, and Ayush Vision 2030, besides exchange of MoUs and other activities. The Curtain Raiser programme was also attended by Alarmelmangai D, Joint Secretary, Ministry of Ayush; Satyajit Paul, DDG, Ministry of Ayush; Dharendra Ojha, Principal DG, PIB; senior officials of the Ministry of Ayush, Central Council for Research in Ayurvedic Sciences (CCRAS), All India Institute of Ayurveda (AIIA), Delhi, National Institute of Ayurveda (NIA), Jaipur, and Morarji Desai National Institute of Yoga (MDNIY); and representatives of the media, among others.

CBI chargesheets Reliance ADA Group in ₹9,000 crore scam case

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Mumbai

The CBI on Monday filed a supplementary chargesheet against three ex-executives of the Reliance ADA Group in connection with the ₹9,280 crore Reliance Commercial Finance Ltd scam case, the agency said in a statement. The latest action came against the firm's group managing director Amitabh Jhunjhunwala, Reliance Capital chief financial officer Amit Bapna, and Reliance Infrastructure Ltd company secretary Ramesh Shenoy. The agency named 14 more entities in the supplementary chargesheet filed before a special CBI court in Mumbai. "The CBI has filed the first supplementary chargesheet today in the Reliance



Commercial Finance Ltd. (RCFL) case...including three executives of the Reliance ADA Group, namely Amitabh Jhunjhunwala, Group Managing Director of the Reliance ADA Group; Amit Bapna, CFO, RCL; and Ramesh Shenoy, Company Secretary, Reliance Infrastructure Ltd," an agency spokesperson said in a statement. The list of accused by the

CBI includes eight companies - Reliance Power Ltd, Big Flicks Pvt Ltd, Reliance Big Entertainment Pvt Ltd, Reliance Communications Ltd, Kunjibihari Developers Pvt Ltd, Reliance Venture Asset Management Pvt Ltd, Reliance Broadcast Network Ltd and Reliance Telecom Ltd. Six bank officials associated with Bank of Baroda, Punjab National Bank and

Indian Overseas Bank are also named as accused, the spokesperson said in a statement. No immediate reaction was available from the company. "The accused have been chargesheeted for offences of criminal conspiracy, criminal misappropriation and cheating under the IPC, along with offences under the Prevention of Corruption Act, 1988," the spokesperson said. In its chargesheet, the CBI said that its probe has so far revealed that funds borrowed by Reliance Commercial Finance Ltd were allegedly diverted to the extent of ₹6,229.54 crore through intermediary and conduit entities to various Reliance ADA Group companies. The diversion, it said, violated the terms and conditions

GAIL, Petronet LNG host MC Plus Hyderabad Connect

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Hyderabad

GAIL (India) Limited, India's integrated energy major, Petronet LNG Limited, and MC² Foundation, in association with IITC Incubator of IIT Hyderabad, organised 'MC² Plus IGNITE Hyderabad Connect' at IIT Hyderabad. Anil K Khandelwal, former CMD, Bank of Baroda, delivered the keynote address. The event was graced by Deepak Gupta, Chairman & Managing Director, GAIL (India) Limited, Akshay Kumar Singh, MD & CEO, Petronet LNG Limited, Professor BS Murty, Director, IIT Hyderabad and Ayush Gupta, Director (HR), GAIL. Speaking on the occasion, keynote speaker Anil K Khandelwal said that innovation dies quietly in fearful organisations. True transformation is never driven by a single initiative; it is built through a culture of customer-centricity, technology, experimentation and continuous learning. Addressing the gathering at the MC² IGNITE event, Deepak Gupta, CMD, GAIL, said that India is at a "remarkable inflexion point", with rapidly growing energy



requirements alongside its ambition to become a developed economy, ensure affordable and reliable energy, build globally competitive industries and meet its climate commitments. Speaking on the occasion, Akshay Kumar Singh, MD & CEO, Petronet LNG Limited, said, "MC²+ Ignite in connecting India's energy indus-

try with the startup and innovation ecosystem, with a focus on leveraging digital technologies such as AI, advanced sensors, robotics and digital twins to make LNG infrastructure smarter, safer, more reliable and efficient." Speaking in the program, Professor BS Murty, Director, IIT Hyderabad shared, "IIT Hyderabad has always placed

innovation at the forefront of its academic and research ecosystem, with a strong focus on translating ideas into solutions that create meaningful impact for society and the nation." Addressing students and start-ups, Ayush Gupta, Director (HR), GAIL, said, "MC²+ Ignite would not only fund innovative ideas but would empower innovators to shape India's energy future. The event also featured an engaging panel discussion on innovation and the startup ecosystem, moderated by Murali Talasila, Ground Game Health, with participation from Vaibhav Kaushik, Nawgati, G Prasad Babu, GCRS, Mileshe Dongre, EyeROV, Varun Kumar, Detect Technologies, Bhuvanesh Kumar Sharma, VDT Pipeline Integrity Solutions Pvt Ltd and Vishwas Chandra Khan, Vasitars. Speaking at the event, Sandeep Maheshwari, CEO, MC² Foundation, said that MC² Plus is India's flagship energy innovation accelerator, envisioned by the Ministry of Petroleum and Natural Gas (MoPNG) in collaboration with leading energy-sector organisations.



Delegation of employees from various public sector banks, led by Girish Arya, Bharatiya Mazdoor Sangh (BMS) calls on Union Finance Minister Nirmala Sitharaman on Monday in Delhi

BSES bags 3 awards at Bharat Electricity 2026

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

BSES won three prestigious awards at the Bharat Electricity Leadership Honours, held as part of Bharat Electricity, POWER-GEN India & Indian Utility Week 2026, spotlighting leadership, operational excellence and sustainable innovation in the power distribution sector. The awardees were selected by an eminent jury of power-sector leaders and experts, and the awards were presented by Shripad Yesso Naik, Minister of State for Power and New & Renewable Energy, Government of India. Ghanshyam Prasad, Chairperson, Central Electricity Authority, was also present on stage.



Amal Sinha, Director & Group CEO, BSES, was named 'Distribution Leader of the Year', recognising a leadership journey marked by vision, institution-building and transformative impact. Under Sinha's leadership, BSES has continued to move beyond the conventional role of a power distribution utility,

with a growing focus on clean energy, battery energy storage, digital intelligence, grid resilience and consumer-centric innovation. BRPL, meanwhile, was named 'State Distribution Utility of the Year' for its sustained focus on operational excellence, reliability, technology-led transformation

and consumer service. BRPL also received the 'Best Sustainable Power Distribution Project of the Year' award for its pioneering 1 MVA SF₆-Free Underground 11 kV Substation. Abhishek Ranjan, CEO, BRPL, accompanied by Team BRPL, received both awards on behalf of the company. Amal Sinha joined the team on stage for the 'State Distribution Utility of the Year' recognition. Together, the three awards underline BSES' continuing journey of transformation, with leadership, innovation, sustainability and operational excellence at the heart of its efforts to build a safer, smarter, greener and future-ready power distribution network.

ONGC chairman selection: 7 candidates in second round

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Seven candidates shortlisted for the top job at State-run Oil and Natural Gas Corporation (ONGC) are likely to appear before a search-cum-selection committee this week, as the Government moves ahead with choosing a successor to Chairman and Managing Director Arun Kumar Singh, people familiar with the selection process said. The second round of interviews comes after 18 applicants were screened on August 18, with the field subsequently narrowed to seven. The selection process has drawn attention over a one-off relaxation in the age eligibility criterion, allowing candidates up to 59 years of age — a departure from the existing 58-year limit and the recent relaxation to 60 years in the case of State-run power producer NTPC, as well as ONGC, in 2022. Oil India Ltd Chairman and Managing Director Ranjit Rath, who is seen as a



frontrunner, is among those shortlisted. Rath, 54, is making a second attempt at the ONGC top job after being shortlisted last year, when the <Government opted instead to extend Singh's tenure. The other shortlisted candidates include ONGC Videsh Ltd Managing Director Rajarshi Gupta, 59; ONGC Director for Technology and Field Services Vikram Saxena; ONGC Director for Strategy and Corporate Affairs Satyam Kumar; OVL Director for Operations Dulal Halder; MRPL Director (Finance) Devendra Kumar and Indian

Oil Corporation Director (Marketing) SP Shrivastava, according to people familiar with the process. The Government earlier relaxed the age criterion for the ONGC appointment, allowing applications from candidates who had not attained 59 years on the date of occurrence of the vacancy — December 7, 2026, when Singh's extended tenure ends. Under the existing norms, the upper age limit is generally 58 years for internal candidates and 57 years for external candidates, while the superannuation age for public-sector executives is 60. Gupta's shortlisting has raised questions because he will be about 59 years and five months old on December 7, making him ineligible under a literal reading of the 59-year condition in the advertisement. Candidates who chose not to apply because they would cross the age limit by the date of vacancy could challenge the selection process if Gupta is ultimately appointed, the people said.

Bank of India felicitates Green Warriors at 121st Foundation Day

PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ Thiruvananthapuram

As part of the celebrations marking the 121st Foundation Day of Bank of India, the Bank of India, Thiruvallam branch organised a special outreach programme to felicitate the Green Warriors - members of the Haritha Karma Sena, in recognition of their valuable contribution towards maintaining a clean and sustainable environment. As part of the programme, the Haritha Karma Sena members were felicitated and provided with QR tags, as an initiative to promote awareness about digital banking and cashless transactions among the community. The initiative aims to encourage the wider adoption of secure and convenient digital payment methods and strengthen financial and digital awareness at the grassroots level. The programme was



chaired by Neil Suresh, Branch Manager, and Sudheesh Achuthan Nair, Chairman, BNV Hospital, was the chief guest of the programme. Rajimol, Secretary, Haritha Karma Sena, Punchakkari Ward, expressed her gratitude to Bank of India for this thoughtful gesture and for recognising the valuable services rendered by the Bank of India. She appreciated the Bank's continued support and initiatives, which have encouraged and helped the Haritha Karma Sena members to strive

towards becoming one of the best-performing Haritha Karma Sena units". The programme highlighted the Bank's commitment to extending its services beyond traditional banking and actively engaging with local communities through meaningful outreach initiatives. The contribution of the Haritha Karma Sena members towards waste management, environmental cleanliness and sustainable development was also acknowledged and appreciated.

Scapia, Axis Bank launch co-branded credit card



PIONEER NEWS SERVICE
■ New Delhi

Scapia and Axis Bank on Monday unveiled the Scapia Axis Bank Credit Card, designed for digitally savvy, travel-first consumers. Available on Mastercard and RuPay networks, the card brings payments, rewards and travel together through the Scapia app, enabling customers to spend, book travel and redeem rewards seamlessly. Cardholders can earn up to 20% rewards on eligible travel bookings and up to 10% on eligible everyday spends. Rewards can be redeemed

across flights, stays, visas, experiences, shopping and more on the Scapia platform. The card also offers zero forex markup, Smart Forex capability and airport privileges across lounges, dining and premium retail. With no joining or annual fee, customers can access fully digital onboarding and card management through the Scapia app. Anil Goteti, Founder and CEO, Scapia, said, "With one app to spend, book trips, and earn rewards, we aim to make travel more rewarding and seamless. Together with Axis Bank, we can bring this experience to more Indians across the country."

NMDC to begin commercial coal production next quarter

ABHISHEK SONKAR
■ New Delhi

State-owned NMDC will start the commercial production of thermal coal by October-December period and looks to sell around 1 MT of the dry fuel within FY27, said Amitava Mukherjee, Chairman of India's largest iron ore mining player. Under the Ministry of Steel, Hyderabad-based NMDC alone caters to the country's 20 per cent need of iron ore — a key raw material needed to produce steel. In an interview to PTI, Mukherjee said the company has drawn a road map up to 2030 to diversify its mining operations to support the Government's vision of Viksit Bharat. "Right now, we are 99.9 per cent an iron ore company. We aim to help the growing industries in the country with maximum of their mineral needs," the chairman said, adding that



this year the company will begin the commercial mining of thermal coal and targets to sell a maximum of 1 MT of the commodity to potential buyers. "We have reached the coal seam (of Tokisud North coal mine), and the production will start by next quarter," the chairman said. The company will also start developing a coking coal mine within FY27 to begin production as early as FY28, he said. "So this year, NMDC will have coal to offer apart from iron ore, and going forward maybe from next fiscal coking

coal too," Mukherjee said. While thermal coal is used to generate power, coking coal is another important raw material used to manufacture steel. NMDC had earlier won the Tokisud North coal mine with reserves of 52 MT and Rohne coking coal block with 191 MT reserves in Jharkhand in an auction conducted by the coal ministry. Mukherjee said the Tokisud North coal mine has an annual peak rated capacity of 2.3 million tonnes (MT) and the Rohne coking coal block has an 8 MT peak rated capacity. (PTI)

Dated: 08-Sep-2026. Place: Noida U.P. Sd/-. Authorized Officer. Axis Bank Ltd.

▼ BRIEFLY

It's always Plan A, there is no Plan B for us: Satwiksairaj



Satwiksairaj Rankireddy and Chirag Shetty do not believe in a Plan B. Instead, the Indian badminton stars prefer to stick to their strengths while making the necessary adjustments to counter different opponents, a formula that helped them conquer the China Masters.

The world No. 5 pair, who had finished runners-up at the 2023 and 2025 editions, stressed the importance of sticking to their strengths while adapting their tactics according to their opponents.

"It's always Plan A, there is no Plan B for us. It always depends on the opponents. The Chinese want to play a fast game. If you are playing with Malaysians and Indonesians, they are not attacking," Satwik said during a virtual interaction on Monday.

PCB starts inquiry concerning conduct on tour of England



The Pakistan Cricket Board on Monday said it has initiated an internal inquiry amid spiralling media speculation of disciplinary violations during the ongoing tour of England from where seven players were called back after massive losses in the first two Tests. In statement that did not any specify violation or the individuals involved, PCB's media head Aamir Mir announced that the Board has initiated the inquiry owing to the media reports.

"The Pakistan Cricket Board has initiated an internal disciplinary inquiry following media reports concerning discipline and conduct, which are currently being reviewed internally," he said. "The PCB handles such matters in accordance with its standard procedure. The process is being conducted under PCB regulations, ensuring all concerned individuals are given due consideration," he added.

Duleep Trophy: Kishan's 270 leads East Zone to 708 against South Zone

G UNNIKRISHNAN ■ Chennai

Ishan Kishan battled humid conditions to construct a monumental 270, reminding the selectors of his red-ball credentials and propelling East Zone to a mammoth 708 on the second day of the Duleep Trophy final against South Zone here on Monday.

Kumar Kushagra too struck his sixth first-class hundred (101, 132b), a shining support act for Kishan's epic, spanning 522 minutes and 334 balls across nearly two days.

South Zone will start fresh on the third day after plucking the final East Zone wicket in the closing minutes of the day. But the most compelling story of the day was of Kishan, whose effort came in the presence of three national selectors. Unfortunately, he could not join an elite club of batters who have scored triple hundreds in Duleep Trophy — Raman Lamba (1987) and Gagan Khoda (2001), but that would not take any sheen out of his knock.

There was something very Virender Sehwag-esque in his innings - the dazzling warmth, the effortless yet brutal acceleration and the innate canniness not to squander the benevolence of conditions. Kishan's first 100, which came on the opening day, arrived in 122 balls but he took 148 balls for the second hundred.

The slowdown was not forced by an exceptional spell or a tough pitch but a more deliberate attempt to wear down the bowlers, and to give his side



the best chance to put on board a total much beyond the opponents' reach. The second first-class double hundred of his career came in 270 balls, when he drilled part-time spinner Devdutt Padikkal for a boundary through the covers.

The only time he looked in discomfort was when left-arm pacer CV Milind managed to ping on his abdomen, which needed a quick medical attention.

But the self-imposed lid on his

batting came soon after going past the double century. He raced to 200 to 250 in just 31 balls. Spinners Shreyas Gopal and Tripurana Vijay suffered most in this Easterly Jet Stream, getting carted for two sixes each.

Kishan blasted 94 runs off 100 balls off Shreyas while Vijay leaked 70 runs off 88 balls, underlining the left-hander's domination. As it was on first day, pulls and drives remained his core run-making shots as 22 fours were made off them.

Europe still untapped market for cricket: Santner

DEVARCHIT VARMA ■ Mumbai

Europe still remains an untapped market for cricket and playing in tournaments like the European T20 Premier League is in a way a contribution to the growth of the game, New Zealand's Mitchell Santner said on Monday. Santner is leading the Edinburgh Castle Rockers in the inaugural edition of the ETPL with his team perched atop the points table with five wins and a no result in six matches so far.

"Growing the game is the most important part. It's a very untapped market in Europe for cricket. If that takes off, that is going to be awesome," Santner told PTI in an exclusive interaction.

"... whatever we can do to try to do that. Playing for New Zealand is still a great thing; I'm still really proud to do that and if we can grow the game and these kind of franchise leagues outside of that, that's perfect."

"If it means that we can come and play in beautiful places, beautiful parts of the world to try to grow the game and put on a show for some fans, I'm more than happy to do that," Santner said. He said different players



stepping up at various stages and retaining the winning combination has been the reasons behind his team's success.

"Boys are gelling nicely on and off the field, which is nice. It's great for the local boys, the Scottish, Irish and the Dutch boys to rub shoulders with some international players," Santner said.

"The standard has been good and we're only halfway. We only got together three days before the start of tournament. We're still feeling it out from the start, but the boys have been really good (with) different guys stepping up at different stages in different games."

You get limited chances in Tests so nothing taken for granted: Padikkal

PRESS TRUST OF INDIA ■ Chennai

Aware that it is not easy to cement a place in the Indian Test XI amid "limited opportunities", Karnataka batter Devdutt Padikkal says he is not taking anything for granted despite back-to-back hundreds in the tour of Sri Lanka.

Due to regular No.3 Sai Sudharsan's foot injury, Padikkal got the chance to play two Test



matches in Sri Lanka and he grabbed it with both hands by scoring 328 runs in three innings.

"You get limited opportunities these days, and it's not very easy to cement a place in a side. Nothing is taken for granted. For me, personally, I just want to keep scoring runs and keep contributing to wins for the Indian Test side. As long as I'm doing that, I'm sure I'll have my place," Padikkal told JioStar.

Gyaneshwari eyes new personal best at Asian Games after Glasgow silver



APARAJITA UPADHYAY ■ New Delhi

Commonwealth Games silver medallist weightlifter Gyaneshwari Yadav is hoping to carry her Glasgow experience into this month's Asian Games, where she has set her sights on bettering her personal best.

The 23-year-old from Chhattisgarh produced personal bests in both the snatch and clean and jerk for a total of 199kg (88kg+111kg) that handed her a silver medal in the 53kg category at the Glasgow Games in July.

"The preparation is going good. I want to get my personal best there. I had given my personal best of 199kg at the Commonwealth Games and I will try and improve on that. "We haven't got a lot of time, just a month," Gyaneshwari told PTI in an interaction facilitated by SAI.

"I will try to improve in snatch. Even if I'm able to improve 1kg each in snatch and 1kg clean and jerk, it will be an achievement for me. For an athlete, getting a personal best is a huge thing."

Gyaneshwari, who is training at the Netaji Subhas National Institute of Sports in Patiala, also hopes to use the experience of competing at the Commonwealth Games to her advantage in Japan. "The experience of CWG I will use in Asian

Games," she said.

However, she will face stiff competition at the Asian Games, where traditional powerhouses such as China, South Korea and North Korea will be vying for the podium.

The Asian Games are scheduled to be held across Aichi-Nagoya, Japan, from September 19.

After the Asian Games, Gyaneshwari will face increased domestic competition in the 53kg category, as Olympic silver medallist Mirabai Chanu, who currently competes in the 48kg-49kg category, is set to move up to 53kg, which is the starting weight for women at the 2028 Los Angeles Olympics. Asian Championships silver medallist Bindyarani Devi has also said she will drop down to 53kg after winning the 58kg bronze at the Commonwealth Games in July.

However, Gyaneshwari, who won the 53kg bronze at the Asian Championships earlier this year, remains unfazed by the increased competition. "I started (weightlifting) seeing Mira didi and now she is saying she will come to 53kg. I will give my 100 per cent and put in all my effort. Baaki competition toh chalta hi hai," she said.

Gyaneshwari has grown increasingly comfortable in the 53kg category after initially struggling to maintain her weight.

DAILY SUDOKU

5	2			6		8		
			3					2
		6	1		9			
4				7				
1			5			4		3
							3	5
					3			
				7		9	3	
2						5		
			8		1		2	7

DIFFICULTY RATING: ★★★★★

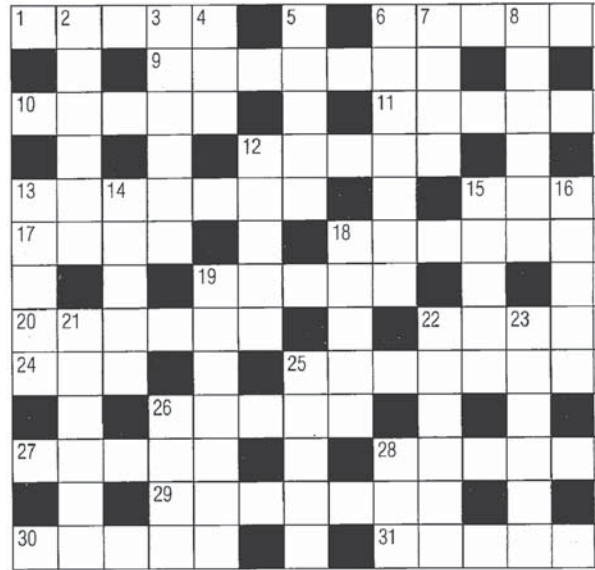
HOW TO SOLVE IT

Sudoku is a logic puzzle where you fill a 9x9 grid so that numbers 1 to 9 appear once in every row, column, and 3x3 box, using elimination and logical deduction- no maths involved.

No. SS2238 Distribution: www.knightfeatures.com

SOLUTION (7.9.26)								
6	3	5	1	8	9	2	7	4
4	1	9	3	7	2	6	5	8
2	7	8	6	5	4	1	9	3
8	5	2	7	9	3	4	1	6
3	6	1	2	4	5	7	8	9
9	4	7	8	1	6	5	3	2
7	8	6	4	3	1	9	2	5
1	9	4	5	2	8	3	6	7
5	2	3	9	6	7	8	4	1

DOUBLE CROSSWORD
TUESDAY | SEPTEMBER 8, 2026



- ACROSS**
- 1 Appeals for readjustment after pa, upset, has left (5)
- 6 No big shout by a player? (5)
- 9 Looked around for things to pop smartly into the shed (7)
- 10 Fishy female? (5)
- 11 Feel that southeast is around north? (5)
- 12 They can be tied at speed (5)
- 13 More or less antique silver or gold (7)
- 15 He has many a little cough (3)
- 17 One islet or eight, we hear (4)
- 18 N. American name for tin (6)
- 19 A rough diamond? Not Di! (5)
- 20 Gave a knowing look before being led

- DOWN**
- 2 Shouting like this is not exactly lordly (6)
- 3 Declare to be a sure thing (6)
- 4 Chuck's bashful (3)
- 5 Starts showing love for writers (5)
- 6 Winner at the wedding? (4,3)
- 7 The days I had ways (4)
- 8 At midnight, muddled heads get injured (6)
- 12 Work at the bakery (5)
- 13 Is aware of swimmers getting a flying start (5)
- 14 Discharged for nothing more than a drunken doze (5)

- out (6)
- 22 English river or a part of Ireland (4)
- 24 Sorry to have said I'm out (3)
- 25 Tilted violently (7)
- 26 He has his own way of working in crime (5)
- 27 Take the wrong seat on the left (5)
- 28 Apply for the job of president (3,2)
- 29 Smooth things over when dismissed at the club (4,3)
- 30 How I am yours (5)
- 31 She hasn't much money (5)

- 15 A blowout for a seaman, as a rule? (5)
- 16 Beaten by one's friend, a dunderhead! (5)
- 18 Mark with two dots (5)
- 19 Roguery, evidently, is more than evil (7)
- 21 Noted flower from a faraway island (6)
- 22 Discerning, unusual taste when out of uniform (6)
- 23 Quarter of the country (6)
- 25 Meat can be a drug! (5)
- 26 Go yachting with Lisa (4)
- 28 Youngster brought up as an equal (3)

SOLUTION (7.9.26)				
ACROSS				
3, Pro-st	22, Al-Ry.			
8, A-5L-on	23, Her-O			
10, Earth	24, Pop star			
11, Si-R	26, B-all-et			
12, Mi-ser	29, Her			
13, Fustian	31, Inlet			
15, Sepia	32, Sea room			
18, Rot	34, D-rake			
19, Basics	35, Ill			
21, Danelaw	36, Let go			
	37, Hedge			
	38, Eld-er			
	DOWN			
	1, Issue			
	2, Portray			
	4, Rain			
	5, See-saw			
	6, Tar-E's			
	7, Sto-ic			
	9, 'Tis			
	12, Mate-lot			
	14, I-on			
	16, Piper			
	17, Astor			
	19, Banshee			
	20, BA-MB-I			
	21, Drill			
	23, Harrier			
	24, Petrol			
	25, Tea			
	27, Anger			
	28, Ledge			
	30, V-Olga			
	32, Skye			
	33, Old			